United Nations S/PV.10165

Security Council

Eighty-first year

Provisional

10165th meeting

Monday, 8 June 2026, 10 a.m.

New York

President:	Mrs. Zalabata Torres/Mr. Amaya Piñeros.	(Colombia)
Members:	Bahrain	Ms. Nancy Abdulla
	China	Mr. Fu Cong
	Democratic Republic of the Congo	Mr. Mukongo
	Denmark	Ms. Landi
	France	Mr. Bonnafont
	Greece	Mrs. Balta
	Latvia	Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes
	Liberia	Mr. Brown II
	Pakistan	Mr. Ahmad
	Panama	Mr. Moscoso
	Russian Federation	Ms. Evstigneeva
	Somalia	Mr. Mohamed Yusuf
	United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland	Mr. Young
	United States of America	Mr. Bartos

Agenda

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2026/431)

This record contains the text of speeches delivered in English and of the translation of speeches delivered in other languages. The final text will be printed in the *Official Records of the Security Council*. Corrections should be submitted to the original languages only. They should be incorporated in a copy of the record and sent under the signature of a member of the delegation concerned to the Chief of the Verbatim Reporting Service, room AB-0928 (verbatimrecords@un.org). Corrected records will be reissued electronically on the Official Document System of the United Nations (http://documents.un.org).

The meeting was called to order at 10 a.m.

Adoption of the agenda

The agenda was adopted.

The situation in Afghanistan

Report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security (S/2026/431)

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): In accordance with rule 37 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the representatives of Afghanistan, India, the Islamic Republic of Iran, Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan to participate in this meeting.

In accordance with rule 39 of the Council's provisional rules of procedure, I invite the following briefers to participate in this meeting: Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan; Ms. Edem Wosornu, Director, Crisis Response Division, Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs; and Ms. Metra Mehran, founder of the Afghanistan Justice Archive.

The Security Council will now begin its consideration of the item on its agenda.

I wish to draw the attention of Council members to document S/2026/431, which contains the report of the Secretary-General on the situation in Afghanistan and its implications for international peace and security.

I now give the floor to Ms. Gagnon.

Ms. Gagnon: Over the past weeks, I have travelled across Afghanistan to remote areas, northern provinces and eastern border areas. In these visits, I have heard a consistent message from Afghan people — returnees, business owners, earthquake- and conflict-affected families, rural and urban communities and women and girls. All have highlighted the increasing pressures they face, whether humanitarian, economic or on human rights.

On the surface, Afghanistan under the de facto authorities remains stable. Territorial and administrative control has been consolidated, and there is no meaningful armed or political challenge to their rule. The de facto authorities themselves present their main achievement as having delivered nationwide peace and security. The longer-term scenarios for Afghanistan, however, depend largely on internal dynamics within the de facto authorities' governing structure, in particular the tension between ideological policies that place severe burdens on the Afghan people and relatively pragmatic approaches that have helped sustain the system so far. For now, what exists is increasing control by the de facto authorities without a clear end state. In this context of accumulating risk and uncertainty, I highlight five interlinked areas: political and economic dynamics; the situation of women and girls; broader human rights developments; regional dynamics; and the importance of sustained, unified international engagement.

Macroeconomic indicators reflect elements of stabilization. Economic growth has been positive in absolute terms, with some long-term investments in infrastructure, fiscal stability has been maintained, and revenue mobilization has improved, despite challenges, such as sanctions, wider regional tensions and the closure of the eastern border since October 2025. Relative stability has also allowed for positive measures, such as the sustained near eradication of poppy cultivation. Key risks remain, however, that underscore the fragility of current economic stabilization efforts, with serious political impacts. The most significant is demographic. Large-scale returns from neighbouring countries have led to a sudden population increase. Nearly 5.9 million

people have returned since 2023, amounting to more than a 10 per cent increase in population. Up to 2.8 million Afghans are projected to return this year, many with limited assets and few livelihood prospects. Afghans are returning to communities and an economy that cannot fully reintegrate them. As the World Bank has reported, in real terms, Afghans are becoming poorer.

To help mitigate this stress, we reinforce the Secretary-General's call on all countries returning Afghans to Afghanistan to uphold their international obligations on protection, including the principle of non-refoulement, and to ensure that returns are voluntary, safe, dignified and accompanied by sustained support for returnees' reintegration. Afghanistan also remains one of the world's largest humanitarian crises. Some 21.9 million people — approximately 45 per cent of the population — require humanitarian assistance in 2026.

Afghanistan's demographic profile is also central to understanding its trajectory. More than half the population is under the age of 25. This generation is coming of age at a time of constrained opportunity, particularly for girls but also increasingly for boys. Many are looking elsewhere for a future. There are economic drivers: limited employment prospects, declining household incomes and rising competition for scarce jobs, particularly in urban areas already under strain from returnee populations. There are environmental pressures: Afghanistan continues to experience prolonged drought conditions, water scarcity and ecosystem degradation. These factors are undermining agricultural livelihoods — the primary source of income for more than 70 per cent of the population — and accelerating rural distress. The convergence of these trends multiplies existing risks, creating conditions conducive to increased migration; social, political and economic alienation; rising insecurity; and potential radicalization.

On the situation of Afghan women and girls, it is important to be very clear. What we are witnessing are severe and growing restrictions — the imposition of systemic and institutionalized harm, with long-term generational consequences for Afghan society as a whole. An estimated 3.8 million girls between 7 and 18 years of age are not in school, including more than 2.6 million adolescent girls. Each year, approximately 250,000 more girls are permanently excluded from secondary education pathways, creating a lost generation of talent and potential. This has implications far beyond education. Recent UNICEF analysis makes clear that restrictions on women's education and labour participation are already costing the Afghan economy and undermining the country's longer-term economic development. Sectors such as health and education are experiencing a decline in qualified female professionals, with projections indicating the loss of more than 25,000 skilled workers by 2030. This directly affects service delivery. It reduces access to healthcare for Afghan people, particularly women and children, and worsens maternal and child health outcomes.

These costs, both human and financial, will only worsen and compound over time. The solution requires the de facto authorities to end restrictions on education and employment for women and girls, to the benefit of all Afghans, and to support opening a new chapter in Afghanistan's relations with the international community. In this context, the continued exclusion of United Nations female national staff from United Nations premises reminds us every day of the harmful impact of restrictions on Afghan women across the country. We again urge the de facto authorities to lift all restrictions on women and girls, including those restrictions affecting the access of United Nations female national staff to our premises, a violation of the Charter of the United Nations.

We are also observing broader trends in the erosion of human rights that warrant increased attention. Recent decree number 18 on separation of spouses violates core principles of the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, in addition to children's rights. It is the most recent of several decrees and actions that serve to institutionalize a system that is increasingly divergent from

Afghanistan's international human rights obligations, and these include recent reports of the detention of approximately 30 women in Herat by de facto representatives of the Department for the Promotion of Virtue and Prevention of Vice and by police for allegedly failing to meet the Taliban dress code. Recent arrests of journalists and the closing of some media outlets highlight declining freedom of expression and the continuing narrowing of civic space.

Relations between Afghanistan and Pakistan remain strained, with continued border closures, security incidents and military signalling. The impacts are immediate, as outlined in the Secretary-General's report (S/2026/431). Border closures disrupt trade flows, reduce access to markets and increase the cost of goods. They also impede humanitarian operations and restrict access to vulnerable populations. Civilian casualties associated with cross-border incidents, as documented in the Secretary-General's report and in reporting by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), underscore the human impacts of this conflict. On both sides of the border, civilians bear the cost of political differences that must be resolved diplomatically.

UNAMA reiterates its call for sustained efforts towards de-escalation and a durable ceasefire, agreement on reopening of border crossings, particularly for humanitarian assistance, and peaceful dialogue to resolve differences, including on the continued presence of terrorist groups on Afghan soil, as reported by the Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team. We welcome the ongoing efforts of Member States to reduce tensions and open channels for dialogue between Pakistan and Afghanistan's de facto authorities.

On UNAMA's efforts to guide a political process leading to the end state defined in resolution 2721 (2023), I reiterate that engagement is not endorsement of the current regime. It is necessary for situational awareness, to facilitate dialogue and to better support the Afghan people. It contributes to the ability to monitor, contain, address and mitigate risks to the international community. Across Afghanistan, at its headquarters and eight field offices around the country, UNAMA and the United Nations system continue to operate as an active presence, engaging daily with communities and Afghan people, supporting humanitarian and basic needs assistance and monitoring, reporting and taking action on real-time political and human rights developments on the ground. UNAMA also engages constantly with the de facto authorities across the country. While significant differences exist, the channels for dialogue are open and frank.

The Doha process is the current format in which dialogue on key political issues take place. It is a multilateral framework that brings together international and regional actors for structured engagement with the de facto authorities towards the Security Council-affirmed end state: Afghanistan at peace with itself and its neighbours, fully reintegrated into the international community and meeting its international obligations for the Afghan people's benefit.

Three years after the first meeting of special envoys on Afghanistan, there has been some progress on a comprehensive approach that serves the Afghan people and supports the international community's objectives. More is needed, however, as highlighted in the Secretary-General's report. We reinforce the Secretary-General's call on the Doha process participants to sustain engagement in this comprehensive approach that supports Afghanistan's eventual reintegration. The de facto authorities are encouraged to establish a structured mechanism for further engagement with UNAMA on this approach. In their interactions with the de facto authorities, Member States should continue to make clear that reintegration remains possible through concrete, balanced, cooperative steps that build confidence and aim to resolve the underlying issues preventing Afghanistan's reintegration into the international system, including the imperative of meeting international obligations.

UNAMA remains invested in achieving the Council's affirmed end state for Afghanistan. Ongoing and constant dialogue is essential, together with principled and pragmatic engagement, even where progress towards the end state is incremental. With strategic patience, coherent and coordinated diplomacy and open dialogue, progress can be made in full support of the Afghan people.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I thank Ms. Gagnon for her briefing.

I now give the floor to Ms. Wosornu.

Ms. Wosornu: Today I will focus on two issues: the humanitarian situation in Afghanistan and the application of the humanitarian exception provided through resolution 2615 (2021).

Afghanistan remains one of the world's largest and most complex humanitarian crises. Nearly half of the country needs help, its need driven by insecurity, economic fragility, climate shocks, large-scale population movement and restrictions that hit women and girls the hardest. Council members heard that from my colleague Georgette Gagnon, Officer-in-Charge of the Mission.

In late February, fighting re-erupted between Afghanistan and Pakistan, displacing more than 100,000 people across the eastern and south-eastern regions and causing several hundred civilian casualties. Already struggling families were pushed even closer to the edge. Approximately 17,000 families in two districts in Nuristan province who were already on the World Food Programme's famine watch list were cut off from all aid for almost two months. Damage to health facilities and schools disrupted services for tens of thousands. While a ceasefire in April has led to a reduction in violence, explosive weapons contamination continues to pose a deadly threat, especially to children.

The conflict has also disrupted critical supply chains, with the continued border closure affecting humanitarian programmes, especially food security and nutrition. A reopening of the border is urgently required to keep the response moving.

Hunger is growing across Afghanistan. Today, 4.7 million people are at risk of severe food insecurity —Integrated Food Security Phase Classification phase 4 — which is 50 per cent higher, compared to the same time last year. Some 3.7 million children are facing acute malnutrition. We continue to receive alarming reports of families forced into desperate choices, including selling daughters simply to survive.

At the same time, cross-border returns continue. So far in 2026, 736,000 Afghans have returned, mostly from Pakistan, adding pressure on host communities and cities already struggling to provide basic services.

Natural hazards are adding another layer of suffering. Spring flooding has killed almost 100 people and destroyed or damaged tens of thousands of homes, alongside health facilities, schools, bridges, hundreds of kilometres of roads and vital crops.

The burden of this crisis is falling especially hard on women. Women-headed households in Afghanistan continue to face some of the highest levels of food insecurity and economic hardship, leaving many mothers to face impossible trade-offs about how to feed and protect their families.

Activities supporting women and girls continue to be disproportionately affected by the de facto authorities and their restrictions, with at least six women's spaces closed in Herat Province since March and the suspension of livelihood activities for women. Female staff have also been stopped in Herat for what the de facto authorities claimed to be inappropriate attire. Over the weekend, we received reports of dozens of women, including women health workers, arrested due to alleged non-compliance with existing

strict dress codes. Across the country, Afghan women remain barred from United Nations premises, as the Council heard — a ban that has now entered its tenth month.

These constraints are not abstract. They have direct consequences on our ability to reach people in need. Women and girls already face severe barriers in Afghanistan. They cannot attend school after the age of 12, they have limited opportunities for employment, and they face restricted access to basic services. When women humanitarian workers are allowed to do their jobs, more women and children can get the support they need. When they are pushed out, their needs often go unmet.

Despite these obstacles, humanitarians continue to deliver. Between January and March, 4.9 million people were reached with at least one form of humanitarian assistance under the humanitarian needs and response plan.

Let me turn to the humanitarian exception provided under resolution 2615 (2021). This marks the ninth briefing to the Council since the adoption of the resolution in December 2021. The message today is clear: this exception is working.

Life-saving humanitarian assistance continues to reach millions of people across Afghanistan. The exception provides the clarity needed for the routine operational payments that make aid delivery and essential services possible. These include everyday operational costs behind all responses: rent on State-owned premises; the withholding of taxes on non-governmental organization staff income; utilities such as water and electricity; visas and permits; security for United Nations compounds and movements; and other fees essential to delivering assistance, including imports, landing costs, licensing, communication equipment and municipal charges.

Since the adoption of resolution 2615 (2021), humanitarian organizations have seen real improvements in access to financial services for aid groups. The proportion of organizations reporting difficulties in transferring funds into and out of Afghanistan has fallen dramatically: from 87 per cent in October 2021, before the exception was secured, to approximately 15 per cent as of May this year.

Our partners are reporting faster transfers and the re-engagement of correspondent banking relationships. Reliance on informal transfer mechanisms continues to decline, with only 16 per cent of organizations reporting the use of *hawala* or other service providers as of May 2026, down significantly from previous years.

Even with this progress, we are still working in a very difficult environment. Bureaucratic and administrative obstacles continue to slow down aid delivery. Restrictions continue to affect humanitarian workers, especially women, as the Council heard again today. Humanitarian organizations face pressure to influence who receives aid and who gets contracts, alongside the ongoing risk that aid may be diverted.

We take these risks seriously, and we manage them. Aid is delivered under strong monitoring and due diligence systems, limiting opportunities for malfeasance and ensuring that any concerns are promptly investigated and addressed. Post-distribution monitoring, verification processes, vetting and re-screening of financial service providers and the establishment of inter-agency feedback and complaints mechanisms have all been implemented. If concerns arise, distributions are paused. Any issues are addressed in consultation with all relevant stakeholders, including local authorities and donors. Operations only resume once clear compliance conditions are met.

An example of this thorough risk assessment process can be seen in the allegations of potential aid diversion in Kunar Province, including a cash-related activity. The partner was immediately notified, and an additional round of post-distribution monitoring and inquiries was initiated to ascertain the claims. A review of beneficiaries found no evidence of fraud or diversion.

We take this very seriously. The collective and coordinated efforts of the humanitarian country team to mitigate risks directly support the effective and responsible implementation of resolution 2615 (2021), which is essential for the timely delivery of assistance in Afghanistan.

Afghanistan's humanitarian crisis is not standing still. It is evolving and, in several respects, deteriorating under the combined pressure of rising needs, declining resources and restrictions on women. The response is being severely constrained by underfunding. This year's response requires $1.71 billion to reach 17.5 million people in Afghanistan. So far, we have received only 15 per cent of that funding.

The consequences are already being felt. Compared to last year, the reach of the response has fallen by 40 per cent, with 3 million fewer people assisted. Without urgent funding, the World Food Programme warns that famine prevention activities for approximately 1.5 million people in high-risk areas will be cut. Support for families at several key border points is also at risk.

I conclude by making three requests of the Council.

First, the Council should continue supporting principled humanitarian action in Afghanistan, including through the full implementation of resolution 2615 (2021). Afghan civilians, especially women and girls, have suffered enough. They should not face further cuts due to the policies of the de facto authorities.

Secondly, the Council should use its influence to press for the protection of civilians and civilian infrastructure and for humanitarians to be able to reach all people in need. Women humanitarian workers must be able to fully and safely do their jobs, and women and girls must have access to life-saving support.

Thirdly and finally, I request that the Council urgently step up flexible and predictable funding. Without more support, we will be forced to cut back even further when people need us most.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I thank Ms. Wosornu for her briefing.

I now give the floor to Ms. Mehran.

Ms. Mehran: I am grateful for the opportunity to brief the Council today. My name is Metra Mehran, and I am the founder of the Afghanistan Justice Archive, a digital repository that documents both the Taliban's repression through directives and decrees and the resistance of women in Afghanistan, in the hope that they will secure justice one day. Our documentation substantiates what women from Afghanistan mean when they call the situation in the country gender apartheid — a systematic, institutionalized and deliberate framework of gender-based oppression.

Since August 2021, the Taliban has enacted over 230 decrees, including the 2024 Law on the Promotion of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice, directly targeting women, girls and LGBTQI+ individuals because of their gender, by denying them nearly every fundamental human right, including the rights to education, employment and health and the freedoms of speech, movement and religion or belief. The Taliban has even criminalized women's faces and voices.

Earlier this year, in January, the Taliban enacted the Criminal Procedure Code for Courts, which builds upon the Law on the Promotion of Virtue and the Prevention of Vice by formalizing discrimination, legalizing violence against women and dividing society into the free and the enslaved. It criminalizes same-sex sexual conduct, with punishment including death. Men effectively own their wives and are explicitly permitted to discipline women using physical punishment, as long as their bones are not broken and their skin is not bruised. The Code treats men as the primary legal authority within the justice system.

Furthermore, the Criminal Procedure Code imposes severe punishments, including lashing, imprisonment and even death, for criticizing the Taliban leadership, and criminalizes failure to report meetings of “opponents of the Government”. In a context in which civil society, journalists and human rights defenders are already facing reprisals and retaliation for their work, this provision further institutionalizes the Taliban’s repression.

In May, the Taliban ratified the Code on Judicial Separation of Spouses, which effectively permits child marriage and further limits women’s ability to obtain a separation or divorce.

Afghanistan’s ethnic and religious groups, especially women from Shia and Ismaili communities, often face the most severe forms of violence and political exclusion at the hands of the Taliban.

The Taliban punishes any violations of its decrees with violence, imprisonment, torture or even death. Moreover, while the *muhtasibs* enforce the Taliban’s vice and virtue policies in public spaces, the system also deliberately compels ordinary men to police the behaviour of their female relatives. For women, there is no freedom within or outside the home. Over the past four years, I have worked with women who resist. They have faced house raids, arbitrary arrests, imprisonment and sexual violence, including forced nudity, rape and gang rape, as well as torture or even death in retaliation for their activism.

Gender apartheid has also pushed Afghanistan into an escalating humanitarian crisis. Today, 21.9 million people need humanitarian assistance, and more than 10.7 million of them are women and girls. Yet women aid workers in Afghanistan themselves face restrictions and exclusion, including bans on entering United Nations premises, rendering effective and principled humanitarian aid impossible. How can women deliver or receive aid when they are not allowed to be seen by or speak to men? The Taliban’s oppression of women is not incidental but central to its model of governance: it has created a system of total control.

Despite the Taliban’s growing repression and complete lack of accountability, some members of the international community are increasingly normalizing relations with the Taliban. Continued engagement with the Taliban has not made it more open to the international community, as some had hoped, but has instead emboldened it to further institutionalize its repression. There has been a lack of clarity from the international community about how it envisions ongoing political processes. This has created profound fear, uncertainty and distrust among people in Afghanistan. For instance, the Doha process, intended to reintegrate Afghanistan into the international community on the condition that it complies with its international obligations, has lost much of its legitimacy by excluding women and diverse stakeholders and actors in Afghanistan in order to secure the Taliban’s participation. The mosaic approach has similarly failed, thus far, to provide a clear road map for principled engagement — engagement rooted in measurable benchmarks, including safeguards to protect the human rights of all people in Afghanistan and stipulating consequences should engagement yield no results.

Since August 2021, the Security Council has adopted several resolutions and press statements condemning the Taliban’s restrictions. Yet, what meaningful follow-up or accountability has actually taken place? When violations are repeatedly condemned without consequences, questions about international complicity inevitably arise.

The women and girls of Afghanistan cannot afford international inaction. Despite our constant disappointment, we still do not believe that the answer is to walk away from those systems. We are pursuing every pathway available to us, whether through the International Criminal Court, the International Court of Justice or the codification

of gender apartheid in the draft crimes against humanity treaty. We know that we cannot afford to abandon those pathways, because our lives depend on whether these institutions, including the Council, uphold the principles that they were created to defend.

Finally, I turn to your current negotiations on the future of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA). Over the past few years, the challenge has not been the strength of UNAMA's mandate but rather the need for its robust implementation, a concern repeatedly raised by civil society in Afghanistan. Given the deepening rights crisis in the country, I urge the Council to ensure that UNAMA's mandate remains firmly grounded in human rights and that the Mission is tasked with prioritizing the implementation of Council resolutions on the women and peace and security agenda across its work. Political or diplomatic engagement with the Taliban must not come at the expense of the rights, dignity and meaningful participation of women and girls. UNAMA also needs impartial and principled leadership at its helm, through the appointment of a Special Representative who will prioritize the concerns of the people of Afghanistan in discharging UNAMA's mandate.

I conclude by urging the Security Council, UNAMA and the international community to do the following.

First, the Council must refrain from political and diplomatic engagement that normalizes the Taliban's repressive policies, including hosting, accrediting or entering into any agreements with the Taliban. As Taliban repression deepens in Afghanistan, now, more than ever, we need the international community to prioritize principles over pragmatism.

Secondly, the Council must ensure the full, equal, meaningful and safe participation of the women of Afghanistan, as well as of civil society organizations, human rights defenders, victim and survivor groups and political opposition groups — both in the work of UNAMA and in all United Nations-led political processes, including the Doha process and future discussions regarding inclusive governance.

Thirdly, emergency protection and resettlement pathways for at-risk women should be created and expanded, and refugees and asylum seekers should not be forcibly returned to Afghanistan.

Fourthly, independent local civil society organizations should receive financial and political support so that they can sustain their critical work in Afghanistan.

Fifthly, humanitarian assistance should be scaled up to meet growing needs. However, to ensure principled humanitarian delivery, aid actors must not comply with any Taliban restrictions that exclude or discriminate against women.

Sixthly, UNAMA's advocacy for human rights, including the rights of women, girls and LGBTQI+ individuals, is critical. It must also strengthen its human rights monitoring and reporting, especially on violations affecting women, girls and marginalized communities, and reprisals against women human rights defenders.

Finally, Member States should support all monitoring and accountability efforts, including through the International Criminal Court and United Nations special procedures. They should also ensure financial support for the Independent Investigative Mechanism for Afghanistan and support efforts to codify gender apartheid in the draft crimes against humanity treaty.

The longer the Taliban's repressive rule is allowed to continue, the more lasting its damage on the lives of Afghanistan's women and girls will be. States, the international community and institutions have legal obligations under international law to act now. We intend to hold the international community to account.

This is not only our fight. It is a test of our global system, of multilateralism and of whether the principles recited in chambers such as this one truly mean anything in practice.

The President *(spoke in Spanish)*: I thank Ms. Mehran for her briefing.

I shall now give the floor to those members of the Council who wish to make statements.

Mr. Fu Cong (China) *(spoke in Chinese)*: I thank Deputy Special Representative Georgette Gagnon, Director Edem Wosornu and Ms. Metra Mehran for their briefings.

The current situation in Afghanistan is generally stable. Yet the challenges in the humanitarian, development and counter-terrorism fields remain complex and severe. The Afghan authorities and the international community should move in the same direction, enhance mutual understanding and trust, take more proactive measures, effectively improve the well-being of the people and promote lasting peace and stability in Afghanistan.

I wish to make four points in that regard.

First, it is essential to maintain the momentum of pragmatic engagement. In recent years, Afghanistan has strengthened exchanges and cooperation with the international community, especially regional countries, playing an important role in maintaining regional stability and promoting economic development. We call on all parties to maintain dialogue and engagement with the Afghan authorities, continuously bridge differences, build consensus and encourage Afghanistan to better respond to the concerns of the international community.

We support the continued effective role of regional cooperation platforms, such as the mechanism of coordination and cooperation among Afghanistan's neighbouring countries, the Moscow format, the Shanghai Cooperation Organization and the United Nations-led Doha process, in helping Afghanistan address various challenges and reintegrate into the international community at an early date. The Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011) should actively support Member States' applications for travel-ban exemptions and expeditiously resume a package arrangement for such exemptions in order to provide the necessary facilitation for engagement and dialogue.

Secondly, efforts to improve livelihoods must be intensified. Despite the positive efforts made by the Afghan authorities, the humanitarian crisis and poverty in Afghanistan have become more acute due to factors such as the sharp reduction in external assistance, large-scale refugee returns, frequent natural disasters and instability in the Middle East. According to United Nations data, nearly half of Afghanistan's population requires humanitarian assistance, more than three quarters cannot meet their basic needs and less than 20 per cent of the required humanitarian funding has been secured this year. Behind those stark figures are tens of millions of Afghans, including women and children, struggling with hunger and disease.

We call on traditional donors to increase assistance to Afghanistan, with countries bearing historical responsibility for Afghanistan, in particular, taking the lead. The countries concerned should return all overseas assets of the Afghan Central Bank, lift illegal unilateral sanctions imposed on Afghanistan and support the rebuilding of its financial system. The Doha process working groups on private sector development and counter-narcotics should strive for more early deliverables, helping Afghanistan enhance its capacity for self-reliant development and deliver tangible benefits to the local population.

Thirdly, the basic rights of the Afghan people must be effectively safeguarded. The report of the Secretary-General (S/2026/431) notes that Afghanistan has, for the fifth consecutive year, enforced a ban on girls' education beyond the sixth grade, resulting in millions of children dropping out of school, which is deeply concerning. Education is the cornerstone of national development and revitalization. We call on the Afghan authorities to place the interests of the country and its people first, take active measures to ensure girls' education, better guarantee women's equal rights to employment, healthcare, access to public services and participation in social life and present an image of openness, inclusiveness and responsibility.

The policy restricting female Afghan United Nations staff from accessing United Nations premises has been in place for several months, seriously affecting the normal functioning of United Nations agencies in Afghanistan. It should be lifted as soon as possible so that the international community can better assist Afghanistan in overcoming its difficulties.

Fourthly, a united international front against terrorism must be solidified. Terrorism is a common enemy of humanity, and counter-terrorism is an international obligation that all countries must fulfil. Although the Afghan authorities have taken action in recent years against Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, that group — along with Al-Qaida, the East Turkestan Islamic Movement, Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, the Baloch Liberation Army and other terrorist groups — remains active in Afghanistan, posing a serious threat to the security of Afghanistan and the surrounding region.

We urge the Afghan authorities to strengthen their resolve and intensify counter-terrorism efforts, resolutely eliminate all terrorist forces based in Afghanistan, including individuals and entities designated by the Committee established pursuant to resolution 1267 (1999), concerning Al-Qaida and the Taliban and associated individuals and entities, and enhance counter-terrorism cooperation with regional countries and the international community in order to safeguard common security.

Since the escalation of border tensions between Pakistan and Afghanistan, China, as a friendly neighbour of both countries, has actively engaged in mediation efforts to promote de-escalation and sustain dialogue between the two sides. In April, representatives of China, Pakistan and Afghanistan held an informal meeting in Urumqi, Xinjiang, China, reaching important consensus on maintaining good-neighbourly and friendly relations between Afghanistan and Pakistan, strengthening dialogue and consultation and exploring comprehensive solutions. China stands ready to continue playing a constructive role and work with both Pakistan and Afghanistan to jointly maintain regional peace and calm.

Over the years, the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) has played an important role in coordinating international assistance to Afghanistan and facilitating engagement and dialogue. China commends this and will continue to support UNAMA in fulfilling its mandate. The mandate of UNAMA is set to expire by mid-June. As the penholder of the Afghanistan dossier, China will make every effort to promote consensus among Security Council members and support the smooth renewal of UNAMA's mandate in order to contribute positively to Afghanistan's development and stability and its swift reintegration into the international community. China hopes that all Council members will make constructive efforts to that end.

Mr. Young (United Kingdom): I thank Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gagnon, Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs Director Wosornu and Ms. Metra Mehran for their briefings this morning.

Let me begin by expressing our deep appreciation to the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) for its work, including its latest report (S/2026/431),

which highlights the fragile and deteriorating situation facing the people of Afghanistan. Today, I will focus on three critical issues: respect for rights, the need for de-escalation and humanitarian access, and the importance of UNAMA and the United Nations-led multilateral process.

First, we are deeply concerned about the continued erosion of the rights of women, girls and religious minorities, which Ms. Mehran has clearly and starkly illustrated today. The Taliban's recent decrees further entrench gender inequality, limit access to justice and formalize discriminatory practices that violate Afghanistan's international obligations. The United Kingdom strongly condemns these draconian and discriminatory measures and laws. We call on the Taliban to reverse these measures and to respect the fundamental freedoms of all Afghans, in line with international law.

Secondly, we reiterate our call for de-escalation and continued dialogue between Afghanistan and Pakistan and for decisive action to be taken against any terrorist groups operating in, and from, Afghanistan. Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gagnon articulated clearly the many impacts of insecurity on the people of Afghanistan, including impeded humanitarian support. An estimated 22 million people across the country require humanitarian support, while facing multiple vulnerabilities, which are exacerbated by climate stressors. In this context, we reiterate the importance of safe, rapid and unimpeded delivery of humanitarian assistance. For its part, the United Kingdom has allocated more than $200 million in essential assistance in the past fiscal year. The year prior, United Kingdom assistance reached at least 2.7 million people, including 1.7 million women and girls. We remain committed to ensuring women and girls make up at least half of those reached by United Kingdom aid, and we are working closely with partners to maintain women's participation in aid delivery and to safeguard access to assistance in spite of increasing tensions and restrictions.

Lastly, as the Council continues its deliberations on UNAMA's mandate, allow me to underscore our continued commitment to ensuring the United Nations continued presence on the ground. The international community has been clear on the need for the Taliban to meet its obligations, and we call on them to engage constructively in the United Nations-led multilateral process towards our collective goal of a stable Afghanistan at peace with itself and its neighbours.

Mr. Bonnafont (France) (*spoke in French*): At the outset, I thank the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Georgette Gagnon; the Director of the Crisis Response Division, Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, Ms. Edem Wosornu; and the founder of the Afghanistan Justice Archive, Ms. Metra Mehran for their statements. I also welcome the presence of the representative of Afghanistan.

Afghanistan has been living under the yoke of the deliberate policy of segregation imposed by the Taliban for nearly five years. France condemns the massive violations of the rights of women and girls that have ensued. Despite appeals from the international community and the Afghan people, the Taliban are pursuing their policy of systematic segregation, blinded by a violent ideology and with no regard for the future of generations of Afghans. Depriving half the population of the opportunity to study, work, receive healthcare and even speak in public constitutes gender-based persecution. This policy is hampering the country's economic development, stoking violence and destabilizing the region. The already critical humanitarian situation has been compounded by the return of millions of refugees. Not only have the Taliban done nothing to prepare for this, they are also adhering to catastrophic choices that are plunging the country into abject poverty. France will not forsake the Afghan people. France is playing its full part, alongside its European Union partners, in providing humanitarian aid in accordance with the principle of "by and for women". It expects the Taliban to allow unfettered access for humanitarian aid and to fully abide by the

fundamental principles of fairness in the distribution of aid, commensurate with needs, starting with those of women and children.

Secondly, the presence of terrorist groups in Afghanistan, specifically Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, Al-Qaida and Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan, is an international security issue. France calls on the Taliban to clarify their stance towards those groups and to undertake tangible and sustained efforts to combat all terrorist groups present in their country.

Thirdly, against this backdrop, the presence of UNAMA on the ground continues to be crucial. What Afghanistan is enduring is not a return to peace and stability, but terror, which is miring the country, its people, and the region in a tragedy with incalculable consequences. France therefore supports the renewal of UNAMA's mandate, which this Council is expected to adopt in the coming days. The Mission is performing a vital role in facilitating the inclusive political dialogue with all Afghan stakeholders, including women and minorities. We trust UNAMA will continue to endeavour to ensure that Afghanistan's international obligations are met, as it has consistently been doing for years. France remains concerned about the situation of female Afghan staff of the United Nations in Afghanistan, who have been barred from the workplace for almost a year. The Council cannot remain silent in the face of the Taliban's systematic obstruction to discharge of the mandate that we entrusted to UNAMA.

Fourthly, the Doha process has not delivered the desired progress. There has been no significant headway in implementing the requirements set by the Council in resolution 2593 (2021) and subsequent resolutions. The Taliban have stepped up violations of international law and refuse to engage in good faith in the political process set in motion three years ago, despite overtures from the international community. France calls for the international community to take meaningful and robust action. Our position remains unchanged: any progress towards Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community hinges on the Taliban's fulfilment of their international obligations. The dialogue process must be inclusive. It must culminate in genuine commitments on human rights. It must serve the entire Afghan population. Absent such efforts, progress is impossible.

In conclusion, I wish to reaffirm France's support for UNAMA, all United Nations agencies and their partners, which are accomplishing tremendous work on the ground, despite the increasingly difficult conditions imposed by the Taliban. They continue to attest to the international community's solidarity with the Afghan people, whom we are not abandoning.

Ms. Evstigneeva (Russian Federation) (*spoke in Russian*): Russia has consistently supported the efforts of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) in the discharge of its mandate. We are convinced that the Mission's tasks must be carried out in full, including those related to facilitating an Afghan-led settlement and improving Afghanistan's socioeconomic situation. Promoting confidence-building and fostering pragmatic engagement between the authorities and the international community remain imperative. It is the key to maintaining a United Nations presence on the ground. We have taken note of the Secretary-General's report on the situation in the country (S/2026/431), and we wish to make the following observations.

In the nearly five years since the irresponsible withdrawal of foreign troops, Afghanistan has come a long way and has stood firm. The Taliban's focus on fostering multifaceted regional cooperation with a view to building an independent and self-reliant State has proven successful. Despite the continued stranglehold of sanctions, painstaking work is under way to address the problems that have accumulated over the years of occupation. However, this process requires both effort and time. It is clear that

a country that has spent 20 years dependent on international assistance needs our collective, non-politicized support.

Russia has consistently championed the development of a realistic comprehensive approach vis-à-vis Afghanistan grounded in objective analysis and a balanced assessment of the situation in the country. This is an imperative, for which there is no alternative, and neither will there ever be any. The key elements of this approach remain unchanged: genuinely constructive engagement by the international community on the Afghan issue, full consideration of the needs of the Afghan people themselves and a trust-based dialogue with the authorities on all outstanding issues. The success of such dialogue depends entirely on the willingness of both sides to engage in it, while fully renouncing the use of pressure and blackmail. This comprehensive approach is shared by all regional actors barring none, particularly by the participants in the Moscow format and its regional quartet, as well as the Collective Security Treaty Organization (CSTO) and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), including the CSTO working group on Afghanistan and the SCO Afghanistan Contact Group.

Overall, the "mosaic approach" articulated by UNAMA itself is also goal oriented. The core of this approach is engagement with the Taliban on all key issues, including securing diplomatic representation, lifting sanctions and unfreezing assets, as well as combating terrorism and drug-related threats and protecting human rights. Addressing these issues in a timely manner without any preconditions is the most direct path to Afghanistan's international reintegration. Attempts to act selectively and with bias, focusing only on those issues that Western donors are willing to discuss, are unlikely to produce the desired outcome. Rather, they will only further delay the prospects for resolving the Afghan issue.

Against this backdrop, it is indeed lamentable that some Western donors have failed to learn from their past mistakes and keep shooting themselves in the foot. They persist in imposing on the United Nations, and UNAMA in particular, their clearly doomed approach, which is based on pressure and ultimatums. It is high time for them to finally realize that through such actions they are only "adding fuel to the fire", jeopardizing the future of the Mission as a whole — a future that, alas, remains uncertain given the reservations of some Council members. It is unlikely that the Afghan authorities themselves would be interested in maintaining United Nations "oversight" merely to serve the interests of the interventionists expelled in August 2021.

We once again appeal to the Secretary-General, who is expected to promptly appoint a new Head of UNAMA. This process has unjustifiably dragged on and on. We also trust that, in selecting the most suitable candidate, the Secretary-General will not only consult with Security Council members but also take into account the views of the Afghan authorities themselves, because the effective implementation of the Mission's mandate will ultimately depend on their consent.

We are concerned by the ongoing tensions between the friendly States of Afghanistan and Pakistan against the backdrop of terrorist activities by the Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan (TTP). We are convinced that there is a vital need to bring the situation back onto a political and diplomatic track. We stand ready to provide assistance and support to our friends. We look forward to the resumption of mutually beneficial cooperation between them, including on counter-terrorism issues.

Another source of concern is the continued presence of Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan in Afghanistan. Unfortunately, the efforts undertaken by the authorities to combat terrorist threats are currently insufficient. The group is consolidating its capabilities, including through recruiting new members and securing external financial support. Terrorists are exploiting every opportunity to destabilize the situation in the country and the region as a whole, including by harnessing the presence

in Afghanistan of militants from the TTP and the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement. It is clear that the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant has not abandoned its plans to establish a caliphate 2.0. We are closely monitoring the activity of foreign terrorist fighters who have gained combat experience in Syria and Iraq. The situation is further aggravated by the unclear status of the weapons abandoned by NATO forces.

The drug issue is another pressing problem, and it is closely linked to terrorism. We acknowledge the Taliban's successes in combating the cultivation of opium poppies. At the same time, we also call for the intensification of efforts to combat another, even more dangerous threat: synthetic drugs, the production of which is currently proceeding at full pace. The definitive eradication of the drug problem will only be possible through broad regional and international cooperation, including within the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime.

The Russian Federation attaches great importance to the socioeconomic situation in the country. We acknowledge the selfless efforts of humanitarian agencies and their staff, who continue to provide assistance to Afghans in need despite the dire conditions, including chronic underfunding. We call on UNAMA to intensify its efforts to unfreeze assets and facilitate development in Afghanistan. Let us also appeal to the Western donors who are so vociferous about the need to protect the rights of women and girls: if they are sincerely willing to help, then help create the conditions for them to live in a stable and developed country. This is particularly important in light of the potential wave of Afghan refugees forced to return from neighbouring Iran amid the armed aggression against it by Israel and the United States.

Russia provides ongoing assistance to the Afghan people. We are prepared to expand our partnerships with Afghanistan across all areas, including regional security issues. We are genuinely interested in enhancing the country's trade and economic capacity and in engaging in dialogue with local businesses through the specialized forums that are being organized by our country. We are closely monitoring developments regarding the protection of human rights and fundamental freedoms in Afghanistan, including the inalienable rights to education and work for all Afghans, irrespective — and I stress this — of their ethnic, religious or gender identity. We are tracking progress towards the formation of a truly inclusive Government representing all the country's ethnic and political groups. We expect to see progress on both these tracks as well.

The Russian Federation sincerely supports the aspirations of the Afghan people to live in a peaceful and prosperous country, free from terrorism and narcotics. The situation in Afghanistan has a bearing on stability in the region as a whole. We once again call on the United Nations to ensure our engagement with those Afghans who directly represent the de facto authorities and are genuinely responsible for what is happening in the country. Only in this way can the existing problems be resolved and Afghanistan be truly reintegrated into the international community.

Mr. Brown II (Liberia): I have the honour to deliver this statement on behalf of the three African members of the Security Council, namely the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Somalia and my own country, Liberia (A3).

We thank the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General and Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) for her comprehensive briefing. We also take note of the vital updates provided by the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and the insights from our civil society briefer.

The A3 remains deeply concerned by the mounting social, economic and security pressures facing Afghanistan. The Afghan people continue to endure the severe consequences of prolonged isolation, economic fragility and deteriorating humanitarian conditions, now compounded by volatile regional dynamics. The A3 reaffirms the vital

importance of sustained, flexible and principled international engagement in support of the Afghan people.

In this regard, the A3 would like to highlight the following core points.

First, the A3 reiterates its unwavering support for the indispensable work of UNAMA. We underline the critical role played by the Mission as a central platform for international engagement, the coordination of basic human needs and the facilitation of pathways towards sustainable reintegration and stability. With this in mind, we emphasize that UNAMA must be afforded the necessary conditions to effectively carry out its mandate at both the national and subnational levels, including through safe, non-discriminatory and unhindered access for all United Nations personnel and humanitarian partners.

Secondly, the A3 expresses grave alarm over the sharply deteriorating humanitarian and economic landscape. The cumulative shocks of severe flash floods affecting 31 provinces, structural underdevelopment and an underfunded 2026 humanitarian needs and response plan, which remains, critically, financed at only 14 per cent, demand immediate international redress. Furthermore, we observe with deep concern that prolonged border closures and regional instability have severely disrupted trade corridors, driving a 10 per cent surge in fuel prices and accelerating food inflation. With 21.9 million people in urgent need of assistance and more than 540,000 returnees placing an immense strain on local absorption capacities, as we heard from the briefers, the international community must act swiftly to close these funding gaps and prevent absolute economic collapse in Afghanistan.

Thirdly, the A3 recognizes that the full, meaningful and non-discriminatory participation of women and girls is a cornerstone for Afghanistan's successful reintegration into the international community. We note with profound regret that the ban on girls' education beyond grade six has entered its fifth consecutive year. We are further deeply concerned about the institutionalization of gender-based hierarchy through the recent decree number 12 on the criminal rules of courts, which systematically undermines the independent legal status of women, expands discretionary penalties and curtails access to justice. The A3 also reiterates its condemnation of the ongoing restrictions preventing United Nations national female personnel from accessing United Nations premises, a directive that explicitly contravenes the Charter of the United Nations. We therefore call on the de facto authorities to immediately lift the discriminatory restrictions on women and girls.

Fourthly, the A3 is deeply troubled by the dramatic 57.7 per cent increase in safety and security incidents, characterized by severe cross-border hostilities. The intense escalation of military operations, air strikes and drone activities along the border has caused hundreds of civilian casualties, widespread displacement and the destruction of critical health infrastructure. We strongly urge all parties to exercise maximum restraint, fulfil their obligations under international humanitarian law regarding the protection of civilians and utilize regional mediation channels to establish a durable ceasefire and secure, predictable border crossings. Concurrently, we reaffirm that Afghan territory must not be utilized as a launchpad for transnational terrorist organizations, including Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and Al-Qaida. We underscore the vital role of the Security Council Committee established pursuant to resolution 1988 (2011) in addressing these enduring threats to international peace and security.

Fifthly, the A3 firmly maintains that there can be no security without development and correspondingly, no development without security across Afghanistan. We are entirely convinced that lasting peace flourishes alongside economic growth, just as progress thrives in an environment of safety and stability. By resolutely integrating robust security measures with the concurrent delivery of economic opportunities,

alternative livelihoods for former poppy farmers and vital State services, we actively unlock the full potential of Afghan communities. Ultimately, nationwide resilience is achieved when we champion security and development as two inseparable, mutually reinforcing pillars of a prosperous future for the Afghan people.

To conclude, the A3 reiterates its unwavering commitment to the sovereignty, independence, territorial integrity and national unity of Afghanistan. We echo the Secretary-General's call for structured, pragmatic engagement through the Doha process, as envisioned by resolution 2721 (2023). Only through a well-coordinated, principled approach across the political, humanitarian and development nexus can we truly meaningfully alleviate the plight of the Afghan population.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): I would like to thank the Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Georgette Gagnon, and Director Wosornu for their briefings, and we also take note of the contribution by Ms. Mehran. We take note of the Secretary-General's report (S/2026/431).

It has been nearly half a decade since the Taliban takeover. It was hoped that this would end the bloodshed and that Afghanistan would be at peace with itself and its neighbours.

To help our Afghan brethren, Pakistan has taken numerous steps to support Afghanistan, including making humanitarian relief efforts, having political engagement, providing incentives to boost bilateral trade, offering transit concessions, issuing student and medical visas, conducting high-level visits to Kabul and participating in various regional cooperation initiatives to help Afghanistan succeed in its quest to find its rightful place in the international community.

With the end of the civil war, it was anticipated that the Taliban would take positive steps to transform itself into a responsible governing authority by adhering to its international obligations and commitments and that it would lead Afghanistan into an era of stability and progress, provide long-awaited relief to all Afghans and live in harmony with its immediate neighbours.

For decades, terrorism has been a major problem in Afghanistan, with implications not only for Afghanistan but also for the immediate neighbourhood and beyond. Afghanistan has a history of being a safe haven for terrorist groups, including those used as proxies by our adversaries to target Pakistan and other countries.

It was our expectation that the Taliban would take concrete and verifiable action against terrorist groups such as Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan (TTP), the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) and its Majeed Brigade, Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, the Eastern Turkistan Islamic Movement and their affiliates, which are operating with impunity on Afghan soil. Regrettably, they have failed to undertake such action, showing complete disregard for the legitimate security concerns of Pakistan and other countries.

Besides the independent analysis carried out and the reports of the Analytical Support and Sanctions Monitoring Team, which clearly outline the terrorism problem in Afghanistan, the realities on the ground and the recent exponential rise in terrorist attacks in Pakistan are glaring reminders of the precarious situation we face today and the threats posed to international peace and security.

As a direct result of the freedom with which these terrorist groups operate in Afghanistan, Pakistan has borne the brunt of their attacks, as well as of the Taliban's growing nexus with those groups. Once again, a significant number of Afghans have been found to be involved in terrorism inside Pakistan. These terrorist groups have access to advanced weapons and sophisticated equipment, including, recently, drones,

and much of this can be traced back to the multibillion dollars' worth of arms and ammunition left behind by foreign forces, which were meant for use by the previous Afghan national Government.

During our counter-terrorism operations, there have been more than 290 seizures of such weapons, which have been used for terrorism and suicide bombings in the western parts of Pakistan and have exacted a heavy toll in human life and material losses. In 2025 alone, Pakistan suffered more than 5,300 terrorist incidents and lost more than 1,200 lives to terrorism emanating from Afghanistan.

Last month, on 9 May, a vehicle-borne improvised explosive device attack by the TTP on a police post in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa martyred 15 police officers. Our investigations revealed that the attack had been planned by terrorists in Afghanistan.

It is deplorable that the Taliban have reverted to their old tactics of providing safe havens to terrorist groups and have chosen the perilous path of complicity, backed by an outside actor — a historic spoiler and instigator of chaos that has moved fast, as an opportunist, to wage a proxy war against Pakistan. Let me make it clear: Pakistan will defend itself against whoever attempts to harm our sovereignty, territorial integrity and national security.

Pakistan has always expressed openness to dialogue. Numerous diplomatic efforts have been made to counsel the Taliban. We thank friendly countries for their genuine mediation efforts, in particular Qatar, Türkiye, Saudi Arabia and, most recently, China, to find amicable solutions.

Yet the Taliban's continued intransigence and even its refusal to publicly denounce and condemn terrorist groups such as the TTP and the BLA are deeply disturbing. It is evidence enough of their complicity and active support for those groups. Pakistan will not sit idle while suffering from terrorist acts; we will respond in self-defence as and when needed and always in conformity with international law, including international humanitarian law.

The most recent report of the Secretary-General seems largely to externalize responsibility for Afghanistan's multifaceted challenges. The fatalities of terrorists and their supporters as a result of counter-terrorism operations are mentioned within the ambit of civilian casualties, posing serious questions about the credibility of reporting by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) from Afghanistan and the nature of its engagement with the Taliban.

UNAMA is swift in reporting incidents of cross-border action and casualties but fails to provide the overall context: the grave terrorist threat emanating from Afghanistan and its cross-border impact directed at Pakistan, which is harming Pakistan and killing innocent Pakistanis.

The Secretary-General's report neither provides information on the destabilizing accumulation of small arms and light weapons inside Afghanistan nor adequately sheds light on Afghanistan's illicit economy, with its complex web of money-laundering and terrorism-financing networks, including the *hundi* and *hawala* networks. Instead, the report resorts to shifting blame to external dynamics, with little regard for the Taliban's own policies, which have brought Afghanistan to the brink of disaster.

We must not lose sight of the fact that it is the Taliban's reckless style of governance and flawed ideologies of extremism, suppression and radicalization that have brought upon Afghanistan the calamities it faces today.

The humanitarian needs and response plan for 2026, as we are told, is only 14 per cent funded — again, a direct result of the Taliban's unwillingness to prioritize the welfare of Afghans over its own interests and authoritarian control.

Several references have been made to the closure of the border. Let me clarify that the closure of the border between Pakistan and Afghanistan does not, from Pakistan's perspective, affect the movement of humanitarian supplies. Pakistan has been processing and facilitating the passage of humanitarian goods and materials. However, the Afghan Taliban regime refuses to let them pass and keeps the border closed on its side, even to such life-saving cargo, which is obviously to the detriment of the Afghan people.

The worsening situation of human rights is also aligned with the Taliban's failings and deceitful narrative to meet the demands of the international community. Women and girls are denied their fundamental human rights and dignity, with discriminatory and abusive practices — a clear violation of their international obligations as well as of Islamic laws, traditions and tenets of the Muslim faith. The Afghan people are being held hostage to these inhumane restrictions, oppression and selfish behaviour.

For over four decades, Pakistan welcomed millions of Afghan refugees despite limitations and insufficient international support, dealing with huge caseloads of illegal Afghans, including those without documentation, posing a serious threat to our security. But these were never meant to be indefinite stays. We call upon the Secretary-General to clearly outline the status of third country resettlement cases of Afghans in a transparent manner — cases that have been pending for years despite being a tiny fraction of what Pakistan had to deal with in the face of national security threats and that no country would tolerate. While we provide all possible facilitation, the international community must step up and shoulder its responsibility. Shifting the blame of Afghanistan's woes to the inflow of Afghan returnees will not solve the problem.

We look forward to the next steps of the United Nations-led Doha process and action plan for its mosaic approach to address Afghanistan's multifaceted challenges comprehensively, with well-defined objectives and a realistic road map as the only viable path for normalization.

Pakistan and Afghanistan are bound by geography, deep-rooted ties, civilizational links dating back centuries, and fraternal bonds of faith, culture and ethnicity. No country has suffered more from the consequences of conflict and instability in Afghanistan than Pakistan. We therefore understand, and we know, that no country stands to benefit more from peace, prosperity and stability in Afghanistan than Pakistan. Pakistan's demand from the Taliban is simple and clear: verifiable and non-reversible action against terrorists. Regrettably, this demand remains unmet. The window for course correction is narrowing but still open. We hope the Taliban realize this in earnest and cooperate with the international community for long-term peace in and the development of Afghanistan and, above all, in the best interest of all Afghans.

Ms. Pavļuta-Deslandes (Latvia): I thank the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan, Ms. Georgette Gagnon, and the Director of the Crisis Response Division of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA), Ms. Edem Wosornu, for their informative briefings, as well as Ms. Mitra Mehran for her compelling contribution. We welcome the Secretary-General's report (S/2026/431).

Allow me to make three points.

First, Latvia expresses its deep concern regarding the severe restrictions on humanitarian access and the growing security risks faced by humanitarian personnel. The humanitarian crisis, already affecting 45 per cent of Afghanistan's population in need of assistance, has been further exacerbated by the Taliban's own actions and policies. According to OCHA, as we heard, around 70 per cent of the 48 reported incidents disrupting humanitarian operations in April were linked to Taliban interference. Restrictions on women humanitarian workers and the ongoing ban preventing Afghan

female staff from accessing United Nations premises are unacceptable and continue to be enforced despite the Council's consistent condemnation. Hostilities, large-scale returns of Afghan refugees and climate shocks have created a multi-layered emergency, but humanitarian actors cannot respond effectively without safe operating space and predictable movement pathways. Prolonged Afghanistan-Pakistan border closures by the Taliban further obstruct aid delivery. Unimpeded access must be ensured without delay. We urge the Taliban to lift all restrictions obstructing humanitarian work, ensure the full participation of women humanitarian staff and guarantee unfettered access for aid organizations across Afghanistan.

Secondly, the Taliban's restrictions continue to deprive Afghans, especially women and girls, of their most basic human rights. These measures contradict the universal principles of dignity, justice and education, as well as international human rights law. On 26 March, Afghanistan entered its fifth consecutive year in which girls are barred from schooling beyond grade six, a policy that has contributed to 2.6 million children being out of the classroom. It is a direct assault on girls' rights and their ability to shape their own lives. Keeping women and girls from schools, workplaces and access to healthcare is also a permanent loss for Afghanistan's future development. While girls remain shut out of school, the Taliban have issued yet another decree, this time effectively lending legitimacy to child marriage. It sets no minimum age for marriage and includes provisions on separation for girls who reach puberty and are married, implying that this practice is permissible. Such a decree constitutes a blatant violation of children's rights and undermines every international norm designed to protect them. These decisions weaken and isolate Afghanistan, denying its people, particularly women and girls, of the future they deserve. We call on the Taliban to reverse those policies immediately.

Thirdly, the United Nations-led Doha process remains the key forum for shaping a coordinated international approach to Afghanistan. Dialogue with Afghan civil society, including women's organizations, is vital, especially at a time when civic space in Afghanistan continues to shrink. We commend the outreach efforts by the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), including engagement with civil society, women activists, tribal elders, journalists and other groups, as well as meetings with youth across 10 provinces conducted this year. In that regard, the timely appointment of a new Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan to lead the political process is crucial.

Among the many issues the Taliban must urgently address is counter-terrorism. Afghanistan cannot become a safe operating space for actors that threaten regional stability and security, and the Taliban must demonstrate through real, verifiable actions that they are preventing such activity. As hostilities between the Taliban and Pakistan persist, we call for continued dialogue, de-escalation and the protection of civilians to remain central in all actions taken.

The case of Afghanistan demonstrates what the women and peace and security agenda has long affirmed: there can be no peace, no stability and no sustainable progress where women are denied their rights and excluded from society. Latvia will continue to speak up for Afghan women and girls and will unwaveringly support the important role of UNAMA with a strong mandate.

Mr. Moscoso (Panama) (*spoke in Spanish*): I thank the Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Georgette Gagnon; Ms. Edem Wosornu, Director of the Crisis Response Division of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA); and Ms. Metra Mehran, founder of the Afghanistan Justice Archive, representing civil society, for their valuable briefings.

Panama also acknowledges the work that the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) continues to carry out in extraordinarily complex circumstances. In a context in which the security and human rights situations are deteriorating in tandem, UNAMA's presence in the country remains indispensable.

The human rights situation in Afghanistan continues to be of profound concern. We are particularly alarmed at the ongoing ban on access by women working for the United Nations to the Organization's premises. We reiterate our call for those measures to be lifted immediately. We are equally concerned that the start of a new school year marks the fifth consecutive year in which millions of Afghan girls are still barred from secondary education. This situation constitutes a grave violation of rights and is jeopardizing the country's economic, social, and institutional future. Afghanistan cannot aspire to stability and sustainable development while much of its population is deprived of the opportunity to contribute fully to the life of the nation.

Panama condemns the findings on the new legal and penal framework promoted by the Taliban. In this connection, Panama wishes to recall that on 9 March, it led, alongside more than 40 Member States, a joint statement conveying our deep concern at the deteriorating human rights situation in Afghanistan, in particular at the recent enactment of a new legal instrument on the rules of criminal procedure (Decree No. 12), which puts systematic discrimination against women and girls on a formal footing. Likewise, we strongly condemn Decree No. 18, which was promulgated in May 2026 by the de facto Ministry of Justice and introduces provisions that, in practice, legitimize child marriage, normalizing a practice that is a grave violation of human rights. This decree is part of a sustained pattern of exclusion and restriction of rights, which, for nigh on five years, has gradually marginalized women and girls vis-à-vis education, employment, the judicial system and public life.

The security situation has deteriorated sharply in the period covered by the report. Clashes between Afghanistan and neighbouring countries have resulted in hundreds of civilian casualties, mass displacement and damage to essential infrastructure. Panama calls on all parties to exercise the utmost restraint, abide fully by international law and make the protection of the civilian population a priority. Furthermore, we reiterate our concern at the persistent threat posed by terrorist groups operating in Afghanistan, including Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, and we underscore the importance of ensuring that Afghan territory is not used to threaten or attack other States. The Afghan population is already contending with immense humanitarian, economic and social challenges. A further escalation would only further compound their hardship. Meanwhile, the humanitarian and economic situation remains extremely fragile. A combination of dwindling international assistance, disruption to trade, mass population returns, inflation and the spillover effects of regional tensions is exerting renewed pressure on Afghan communities.

Panama supports a renewal of UNAMA's mandate and the full implementation thereof, with a robust focus on human rights and the women, peace and security component. Now more than ever, Afghanistan needs a United Nations presence capable of supporting the country, safeguarding channels for dialogue and promoting respect for human rights and the full equal and meaningful participation of women so as to coordinate the international response to the many challenges it faces. It is our duty to redouble our collective efforts to move towards an Afghanistan that is at peace with itself and fully integrated into the international community — one in which all its citizens can fully exercise their rights and fulfil their potential.

Mr. Bartos (United States of America): I thank Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gagnon, Director Wosornu and Ms. Mehran for their briefings.

The United States top priority in Afghanistan remains the protection of our citizens and the safeguarding of our national security. The Taliban's abhorrent practice of hostage diplomacy continues, and we call on all members of the Security Council to condemn the Taliban for their unjust detention of United States citizens. We also call on all Council members to echo our condemnation of the Taliban's sheltering of terrorist groups and their refusal to implement counter-terrorism commitments.

Furthermore, the Taliban continue to inflict constant hardship and suffering on the people of Afghanistan. Their oppressive policies have exacerbated already severe humanitarian and economic crises. By limiting access to basic services, obstructing the delivery of international humanitarian aid and committing serious human rights abuses, most notably the systemic and unconscionable restrictions on the exercise of women's rights, the Taliban demonstrate their blatant disregard for the well-being of the Afghan people. As today's briefers have so clearly described, the Taliban continue their appalling and, frankly, horrific treatment of the women and girls of Afghanistan.

The Taliban's actions also impede the functioning of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), including by preventing Afghan female staff from entering United Nations premises across the country. The Taliban's intransigence forces us to ask hard questions about the value of continued international engagement and resources. UNAMA remains the most expensive special political mission in the United Nations system, warranting close scrutiny. All missions, including UNAMA, must provide value for money and must adapt to conditions on the ground. The United States appreciates Council members using the upcoming mandate renewal to improve UNAMA's effectiveness, and we look forward to the adoption of a streamlined resolution.

On the diplomatic front, the United Nations-led comprehensive approach provides a potential path forward, and the Taliban must engage seriously. Any step towards normalization depends entirely on the Taliban's own actions, including progress on the issues raised through this process. Tangible progress in the Doha process is not optional; it is urgent. The international community cannot indefinitely sustain a framework for engagement, while the Taliban detain innocent Americans, ignore the needs of the Afghan people, deny Afghan women their basic rights and fail to meet their counter-terrorism commitments.

Equally urgent is the appointment of a qualified, empowered Special Representative of the Secretary-General. The absence of a permanent Special Representative of the Secretary-General weakens the international community's ability to coordinate, advocate and hold the Taliban accountable. That vacancy must be filled without further delay.

This Council must continue to demand responsible actions from the Taliban. Actions — not words — are a fundamental requirement for international peace and security, and the people of Afghanistan deserve no less.

Ms. Landi (Denmark): Let me thank Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gagnon, Director Wosornu and Ms. Mehran for their valuable briefings.

Nearly five years after the Taliban's violent seizure of power, Afghanistan remains trapped in a cycle of systemic repression and humanitarian suffering, with no meaningful steps taken to reverse course. Allow me to make three points.

First, we are deeply appalled by the Taliban's widespread dismantling of fundamental rights and freedoms in Afghanistan. The scale and severity of these restrictions, particularly against women and girls, are unparalleled. These are not isolated acts, rather they are a deliberate pattern of institutionalized gender-based

discrimination and exclusion, as outlined so powerfully by Ms. Mehran. Girls remain barred from secondary and higher education. Women are excluded from most employment. Their movement is restricted. Their access to justice is curtailed, and their participation in public life has been eliminated.

Decree No. 18 represents another deeply troubling step on this trajectory. It effectively legitimizes marriage for children as young as nine and allows a girl's silence to be interpreted as consent. Let us be clear: silence is not consent, and a 9-year-old girl is not an adult. Denmark strongly condemns Decree 18 and all measures that discriminate against women and girls or restrict the fundamental rights and freedoms of the Afghan people. The Taliban must immediately bring their laws, policies and practices into full compliance with Afghanistan's international human rights obligations. We also call for strengthened international efforts to hold the Taliban accountable for violations of international law, including through United Nations mechanisms, the International Criminal Court and strengthened support to the Independent Investigative Mechanism for Afghanistan.

Secondly, the humanitarian situation is becoming increasingly desperate, with more than 21 million Afghans in need of humanitarian assistance and widespread acute food insecurity and malnutrition. Needs are further driven by displacement; climate shocks, including water scarcity; economic hardship; and regional instability, including cross-border hostilities. At the same time, humanitarian agencies are stretched to the limit, operating under severe funding shortages and increasingly constrained conditions, as pointed to by Ms. Wosornu. Denmark also remains deeply concerned by the continued ban on Afghan female United Nations personnel. United Nations personnel serve on behalf of all of us. Restrictions on their work undermine not only the delivery of assistance but also the implementation of this Council's mandate. We once again demand that the Taliban ensure full, safe, rapid and unhindered humanitarian access across Afghanistan and remove all restrictions on female personnel.

Thirdly, Afghanistan must never again become a safe haven for terrorism, and its territory must not be used to threaten or attack any country. We call on the Taliban to take sustained action against all terrorist groups operating in or from Afghanistan, including Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan and Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, in line with this Council's resolutions. The recent hostilities between Afghanistan and Pakistan further underscore the ongoing regional tensions. We call for restraint and continued efforts to reduce tensions, including China's facilitation of dialogue, to support de-escalation and a durable ceasefire. All parties must comply with international law and protect civilians and civilian infrastructure, in line with international humanitarian law.

In closing, let me extend Denmark's strong appreciation to the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and all United Nations personnel working under incredibly difficult circumstances across Afghanistan. Ahead of UNAMA's mandate renewal, Denmark supports a strong United Nations presence on the ground, with a clear focus on human rights, humanitarian coordination and good offices. The women and peace and security agenda must remain central to all United Nations engagement on Afghanistan, with women's rights, participation and protection fully integrated across political, humanitarian and governance efforts, including in the Doha process. To this end, we call for the appointment of a United Nations Special Envoy and reiterate the need to appoint a Special Representative without delay.

Mrs. Balta (Greece): I would like to thank Deputy Special Representative, Georgette Gagnon, Director Edem Wosornu of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and Ms. Metra Mehran for their remarks and to welcome the presence of the representative of Afghanistan in the meeting.

While Afghanistan is experiencing a period of relative calm, deep-seated political, economic, social and environmental challenges reveal the fragile nature of this reality. The human rights situation continues to deteriorate, particularly for women and girls, as restrictive measures are tightened instead of being reversed.

I would like to make the following three points today.

First, restrictions on the human rights and fundamental freedoms of women and girls have reached, as we heard today from our briefers, unprecedented levels, preventing their effective participation in public and private life. For the fifth consecutive year, girls remain banned from secondary and higher education. Since September 2025, women United Nations personnel have been barred from their offices, severely impacting the delivery of humanitarian assistance and healthcare to women across the country. This systemic regression is further exacerbated by the recent decree on criminal rules of courts, which legitimizes violence against women and child marriage. Moreover, the ongoing erosion of freedom of expression and media freedom, as evidenced by the suspension of media outlets and organizations, is deeply alarming. We urge the Taliban to immediately lift these restrictions and oppressive measures, restore full access to education for girls and permit Afghan women United Nations personnel to return to their workplaces. We call upon the Taliban to honour Afghanistan's international commitments, particularly the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women, and we affirm our support for all means of accountability. Additionally, we reiterate the critical importance of free, independent and pluralistic media.

Secondly, we reaffirm our principled position that the territory of Afghanistan must never serve as a safe haven for terrorism, and we call on the Taliban to take all necessary measures to combat terrorist activities, including those targeting neighbouring countries. We remain concerned by the cross-border clashes between the Taliban and the Pakistani security forces over the past months, which resulted in numerous civilian casualties, the destruction of civilian infrastructure and disruptions to the delivery of humanitarian assistance due to border closures. We welcome the reduction in tension over recent weeks and all mediation efforts by regional countries, most recently by China. We reiterate our call for de-escalation, a ceasefire and a peaceful resolution of disputes through dialogue and diplomacy. We underline the importance of adherence to international law, including international humanitarian law and the protection of civilians. The unhindered delivery of humanitarian assistance through secure and predictable border crossings is essential, especially as Afghanistan grapples with unprecedented levels of food insecurity and child malnutrition, extreme environmental conditions and an influx of returnees.

Thirdly, Greece reiterates its full support for the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and its indispensable role in facilitating political dialogue in Afghanistan, coordinating the delivery of humanitarian assistance and monitoring the human rights situation. We therefore support the upcoming renewal of UNAMA's mandate in its entirety and call for its swift conclusion. In parallel, we urge the Taliban to establish the long-awaited mechanism for engagement with UNAMA's comprehensive approach. The Doha process remains an important framework for the reintegration of Afghanistan into the international community, provided that the Taliban abide by their international obligations regarding human rights, inclusive governance and counter-terrorism.

The Afghan people cannot afford continued isolation from the international community. The time has come for the Taliban to recognize this reality and engage meaningfully with UNAMA and the relevant national and international stakeholders.

Ms. Nancy Abdulla (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), and Ms. Edem Wosornu, representative of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, for their comprehensive briefings and for the overview they provided of the latest developments in Afghanistan and the challenges the country is facing.

The Kingdom of Bahrain values the efforts made by UNAMA and its staff in carrying out the Mission's mandate, despite the complex political, security and humanitarian challenges surrounding its work. I also thank Ms. Metra Mehran for her valuable briefing.

The Kingdom of Bahrain emphasizes the importance of the role that UNAMA continues to play in supporting international efforts in Afghanistan, including coordinating assistance, maintaining channels of dialogue and monitoring political, human rights and security developments across the country. This role is becoming increasingly important in view of the Secretary-General's most recent report (S/2026/431), which highlights persistent social, economic and security pressures stemming from a decline in assistance, the return of large numbers of Afghans from neighbouring countries and border and regional tensions, in addition to the impact of disruptions in trade and supply chains on the humanitarian and economic situation in Afghanistan.

In this context, the Kingdom of Bahrain would like to emphasize three main points.

First, the Kingdom expresses its deep concern regarding the continuing restrictions affecting the situation of women and girls in Afghanistan, particularly in the areas of education, employment and participation in public life, depriving Afghan society of half the capacity needed to achieve stability, recovery and development. The ban on girls' education beyond the sixth grade has now entered its fifth year, while restrictions on Afghan female staff working with UNAMA prevent them from gaining access to their workplaces. The Kingdom calls for these restrictions to be addressed and lifted and for women and girls to be empowered to exercise their fundamental rights, including the rights to education, employment and safe and meaningful participation in public life.

Secondly, on the humanitarian and economic fronts, the situation in Afghanistan remains worrisome, as the Secretary-General's most recent report indicates that more than 21 million people are in need of humanitarian assistance, at a time when the 2026 humanitarian response plan continues to face a significant funding shortfall. These pressures are intensifying with the continued return of large numbers of Afghans and the strain on essential services. In this context, the Kingdom emphasizes the importance of ensuring that the humanitarian response addresses the actual needs of the Afghan people and guarantees that aid reaches those in need of it without discrimination, thereby limiting the deterioration of living conditions and supporting the path to recovery and stability.

Thirdly, the Kingdom of Bahrain emphasizes the importance of continuing the Doha process of meetings of special envoys on Afghanistan, organized by the United Nations with the support of the fraternal State of Qatar, as a structured multilateral framework to support international engagement on Afghanistan, thereby contributing to addressing priority issues and achieving practical, tangible results that serve the Afghan people. We also stress the importance of building on the working groups convened within this framework, particularly in practical areas related to combating narcotics and supporting the private sector, thereby promoting recovery and stability.

The Kingdom also underscores that the stability of Afghanistan hinges on addressing cross-border threats and ensuring that the country is not used as a safe haven

or launchpad by any terrorist groups to threaten the security of any State. The Kingdom of Bahrain therefore condemns all terrorist attacks, including the terrorist attack carried out by Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan, which targeted a police post in the Bannu district on 9 May. The Kingdom affirms its solidarity with the Islamic Republic of Pakistan in confronting extremism and terrorism and its support for the country's security and stability, while reiterating its categorical rejection of all forms of violence and terrorism aimed at undermining security and stability and terrorizing innocent people.

In conclusion, the Kingdom of Bahrain reaffirms its support for UNAMA and for international efforts to achieve security, stability and prosperity in Afghanistan, in a manner that serves the Afghan people and safeguards regional and international security and stability.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I shall now deliver a statement in my capacity as the representative of Colombia.

I thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Afghanistan and Officer-in-Charge of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA), Ms. Edem Wosornu, Director of the Crisis Response Division of the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, and Ms. Metra Mehran for their briefings. I also welcome the delegations that are with us today.

My delegation takes note with concern of the most recent report on the situation in Afghanistan (S/2026/431), which continues to provide evidence of the complex situation on the ground and the need to continue working to promote the well-being of the entire Afghan people. Colombia reiterates its condemnation of human rights violations, in particular gender-based discrimination. It is alarming that Afghan women and girls continue to be severely affected by restrictions in all areas of their lives, including the ban on education beyond sixth grade. These measures increase the exposure and vulnerability of women and girls to all manner of violence, including sexual and gender-based violence.

My country reiterates the call for the Taliban to rescind all policies and practices that restrict the rights of women and girls without delay. It is imperative that full equal access to quality education, health and other basic services be guaranteed, along with freedom of movement, access to justice, economic opportunities and employment and full, equal and meaningful participation in public life. Peace and sustainable development for Afghanistan will remain unattainable as long as half the population continues to be systematically excluded. Moreover, it is worrisome that 45 per cent of the Afghan population is in need of humanitarian assistance, amid a crisis that continues to worsen. It is urgent to ensure full, rapid, safe and unhindered humanitarian existence, in line with the rules of international humanitarian law.

Colombia reiterates the call to lift the restrictions preventing Afghan women from working for the United Nations and non-governmental organizations and from gaining access to United Nations premises in Afghanistan. The exclusion of women from the humanitarian response undermines the reach and effectiveness of the assistance provided, limits access to women and girls and exacerbates gender-based violence and protection risks. Safe spaces must be guaranteed, and all restrictions that hinder the inclusive, effective and gender-sensitive delivery of humanitarian assistance must be eliminated.

Attention must be paid to the increase in threats to the fulfilment of the basic human needs of a large part of the population, including the 2.9 million Afghans who have returned to Afghanistan. Women and girl returnees face additional vulnerabilities, owing to discriminatory restrictions, obstacles to reintegration and limited opportunities. Colombia echoes the Secretary-General's call to guarantee protection, including the

principle of non-refoulement, and to ensure that returns are voluntary, safe, dignified and accompanied by sustained support for the reintegration of returnees.

In conclusion, I want to reaffirm the continuing role of UNAMA and the United Nations country team in facilitating dialogue, supporting the Afghan people, reviving a coherent and coordinated international approach and addressing key concerns, such as the protection of human rights and the adverse effects of climate change. An Assistance Mission with a robust mandate, a human rights-based approach and a gender-sensitive focus remains necessary to achieve a peaceful Afghanistan for the well-being of all Afghan people and for regional stability.

I resume my functions as President of the Council.

I now give the floor to the representative of Afghanistan.

Mr. Faiq (Afghanistan): At the outset, allow me to congratulate Colombia on assuming the presidency of the Security Council and to wish you, Madam President, and your team every success this month. We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Ms. Gagnon, and Director Wosornu for their sobering briefings and Ms. Metra Mehran for bringing the voices of Afghan women into this Chamber. We also thank the Council members and previous speakers for their continued support for and solidarity with the people of Afghanistan.

Today, I want to share the perspective of ordinary people of Afghanistan, the deep concerns, frustrations and aspirations they convey to us every day from inside the country. Nearly five years after the Taliban's military takeover, Afghanistan remains trapped in a deep political, economic, social and humanitarian crisis. The facts are clear and well documented. The real question before this Council is whether this situation is sustainable and whether the international community is prepared to move beyond managing the consequences of this crisis towards addressing the root causes, in the interests of the Afghan people and international community.

Allow me to highlight five realities that cannot be ignored and five suggestions or imperatives that should guide our collective response.

First, Afghanistan faces a profound human and social crisis. Twenty-two million Afghans — two-thirds of the population — remain dependent on urgent humanitarian assistance. Poverty and unemployment are widespread, economic opportunities are shrinking, and an entire generation of young Afghans and women no longer see a future for themselves in their own country. The loss of human capital, deepening poverty, rising forced and early marriages, psychological distress and growing criminality are clear signs of a society breaking under the weight of exclusion and injustice. The imperative: Afghanistan needs a national vision focused on job creation, standard and modern education and human development. The country cannot move forward while excluding large segments of its population from contributing to its future. Most importantly, this vision requires a political horizon that leads to a broad-based, legitimate and representative Government that provides the foundation for long-term stability.

Secondly, in that context, the Taliban governance has failed the people of Afghanistan. A model of governance designed by the Taliban and exclusively for the Taliban has no accountability to the people it claims to govern. Corruption, the abuse of power and the concentration of wealth within a narrow circle are well documented. Meanwhile, Afghanistan's mineral wealth is extracted without transparency or public oversight. The Taliban have consistently ignored both the demands of the people of Afghanistan and the repeated appeals of the international community. The imperative: Afghanistan needs a legitimate, accountable and law-based system of governance that derives its authority from the consent of its people and uses national resources for the benefit of all citizens.

Thirdly, the systematic exclusion and discrimination have pushed Afghanistan further into isolation. This year marks the fifth consecutive year in which Afghan girls have been denied access to secondary and higher education. Women have been removed from public life, civil society space has been restricted, and independent media has been subjected to censorship. The Taliban have further codified this discrimination through laws that restrict accountability for domestic violence and permit child marriage under the guise of silent consent. These are not temporary measures. These are deliberate and systematic efforts to exclude half of society from public life — an approach that has absolutely no basis in the true principles of Islam or in Afghanistan's own history and traditions. We remain deeply concerned by the continued and verified reports of arbitrary detention, torture, sexual violence, forced marriages, targeted reprisals and other serious human rights violations, particularly against women and girls, human rights defenders, former security forces and media personnel.

The imperative: besides the United Nations and the European Union and regional and international organizations, Islamic countries and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation must play a more active role in making clear to the Taliban that these draconian policies not only pose a threat to the future of Afghanistan but also harm the image of Islam worldwide. The reopening of schools and universities to girls must remain a non-negotiable priority for the international community as a whole. Additionally, monitoring, reporting and accountability mechanisms should be strengthened and used effectively to end the impunity.

Fourthly, normalizing the current situation serves neither the people of Afghanistan nor international peace and security. Engagement without tangible results and concessions without behavioural change have not improved governance, human rights or political inclusion. Normalizing systematic exclusion and political repression will not bring stability. Mixed messages and contradictory approaches have only prolonged the current impasse and emboldened the Taliban. The imperative: the Security Council needs a stronger, more unified and coherent approach. The message must be clear and consistent. There is no path to our legitimacy or Afghanistan's reintegration into the international community without full respect for human rights, women's rights, inclusive governance and international obligations.

Fifth is the rise of insecurity and the risk of Afghanistan again becoming a platform for extremism and terrorism. The absence of war should not be mistaken for the presence of genuine peace. True peace exists when girls and boys have equal access to quality education, when women can participate fully and meaningfully in society and when all citizens enjoy their fundamental rights and freedoms without intimidation and prejudice and are not forced into armed resistance. The targeted killings of members of the Shia and Hazara communities in public places, including in the Injil District of the Herat Province, alongside the unexplained deaths of civilians, hostage-taking and the murder of a female United Nations staff member two days ago do not reflect genuine peace and security in Afghanistan. Furthermore, the continued expansion of Jihadi madrasas and the persistent presence of international terrorist groups, as confirmed by successive United Nations reports, raise serious concerns for the people of Afghanistan, the region and the international community. The Taliban's policies and continued links with terrorist groups have endangered the people of Afghanistan in the past and continue to do so today. But this also presents a threat to regional and international peace and security, and we hope this issue receives the attention it warrants by the Council.

The recent escalation of hostilities between Pakistan and the Taliban has added a dangerous new dimension to this crisis and resulted in significant civilian casualties. Particularly alarming was the reported strike on Omid Drug Rehabilitation Hospital in Kabul, a civilian medical facility, where the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) verified at least 269 people killed and 122 injured. We strongly

condemn all attacks that result in harm to civilians, the destruction of critical infrastructure and violations of Afghanistan's territorial integrity. We ask the Council to condemn and prevent such attacks.

No security concern, however legitimate, can justify actions that place civilians at risk or undermine the principles of the Charter of the United Nations and international humanitarian law. Afghanistan has long been a victim of terrorism, and its people have suffered immensely from its devastating consequences. We therefore also strongly condemn all terrorist attacks in Pakistan and elsewhere and reaffirm the need for collective efforts to combat terrorism in all its forms and manifestations everywhere. It is imperative for the international community and regional countries to adopt a comprehensive coordinated and principled strategy to address terrorism, violent extremism and narcotics trafficking. Such threats can be addressed sustainably only through the establishment of a legitimate inclusive representative and accountable Government that is committed to upholding its national and international obligations and ensuring that Afghanistan never again becomes a source of instability and insecurity for its people, the region and the wider world.

All of these realities point to one unavoidable conclusion: at its core, Afghanistan's crisis remains a complex political crisis. Humanitarian and economic assistance remain essential to alleviating suffering, but they cannot substitute a durable and sustainable political solution. Without a credible political process, we risk pushing Afghanistan towards a civil war. We continue to support the central role of the United Nations, the implementation of resolution 2721 (2023) and efforts to advance a credible, inclusive and Afghan-owned political process that leads to a legitimate, representative and accountable political order. In this regard, the role of UNAMA remains crucial in facilitating such a process in accordance with its mandate and in ensuring the meaningful participation of all credible and relevant stakeholders. As negotiations on the renewal of UNAMA's mandate continue, we reiterate our support for preserving a strong, balanced and effective mandate. We also emphasize the importance of the timely appointment of a highly qualified Special Representative of the Secretary-General who possesses a deep knowledge of Afghanistan, is firmly committed to impartiality, human rights and conflict resolution and is capable of advancing a comprehensive political process aimed at achieving lasting peace and stability in Afghanistan.

In conclusion, we call on the Council to maintain a strong, unified and consistent position. There is no path to legitimacy, stability or reintegration without respect for human rights, inclusive governance and international law. Engagement with the Taliban should be principled and conditioned on measurable and verifiable progress, and all stakeholders, including Islamic countries and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, have a unique responsibility to make that message heard in Kabul. Accountability mechanisms should be used to end impunity, and effective action against terrorism and extremism ultimately requires a Government in Afghanistan that's legitimate and accountable to its people and to the world. The people of Afghanistan are not the cause of this crisis; they are its victims. They want a country where girls can go to school, where young people can look to the future with hope, where women can work and live freely and where the Government derives its legitimacy from the will of its people. Helping them to achieve that future should remain our shared responsibility.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Parvathaneni (India): I congratulate Colombia on assuming the presidency of the Council. I thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon, Head of Mission of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and Deputy Special Representative of the Secretary-General for briefing this meeting. We also take note of the briefings from

Director Wosornu from the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs and Ms. Mehran.

India and Afghanistan are contiguous neighbours and as civilizational States our ties have spanned centuries. Our history of close cooperation continues to guide our modern-day relationship. The proud people of Afghanistan have endured a lot in this century, and the Government of India will continue to stand in favour of peace and stability so as to foster development and stability in this nation. Our participation in the Doha working group meetings and our strong bilateral development partnerships stand testimony to this promise.

India's capacity-building and humanitarian assistance initiatives for the Afghan people can be seen in all 34 provinces and in more than 500 development partnership projects. We are focusing on healthcare, public infrastructure and capacity-building. We are intensifying our cooperation with United Nations agencies and others such as the Afghan Red Cross Society in priority areas for the Afghan people. The visits of Afghan ministers to India last year have ensured necessary planning and coordination so that our support reaches the intended beneficiaries.

Having suffered years of active hostilities, generations of Afghans are now suffering from neglect by the international community. In April 2026, India delivered three tons of specialized flood relief supplies to support communities affected by recent floods. The consignment included kitchen sets, dignity and hygiene kits, plastic sheets, tarpaulins, sleeping bags and more. In its commitment to strengthening Afghanistan's child immunization programme, India has recently delivered 33 tons of BCG, tetanus and diphtheria vaccines and related dry materials to Kabul. It gives us great satisfaction to report that now Afghan children suffering from acute congenital heart diseases are being treated in India. The establishment of maternity clinics in rural areas in Paktika, Khost and Paktiya, the upgrading of the Indira Gandhi Institute of Child Health and the construction of oncology and trauma centres in Kabul also underline our commitment to Afghan women and children. We thank our partner agencies, including UNICEF and the Afghan Red Crescent Society, in this regard. The setting up of an oncology centre, a trauma centre, the imminent installation of advanced medical devices across hospitals and the construction of a 30-bed hospital in Kabul and a thalassemia centre in Herat will provide much needed healthcare support.

Since August 2021, my country has supplied more than 50,000 tons of wheat, 420 tons of medicines and vaccines, including anti-cancer medicines and medicines for vector diseases, as well as 40,000 litres of pesticides. The two earthquakes that ravaged Afghanistan last year call for more support. India was among the first to provide humanitarian assistance to the tune of 60 tons of food, 42 tons of earthquake relief materials and 73 tons of essential medicines. In partnership with the United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime, we have provided 68 tons of medical supplies and 34 tons of social support items for the rehabilitation of drug addicts.

In the field of education, our scholarship and fellowship schemes for Afghan students are always in demand. Since 2023, approximately 3,000 students have availed themselves of these opportunities, including 1,000 Afghan women. Another 1,000 scholarships will also be offered very soon for the pursuit of degree courses, including Master courses. India continues to provide financial and logistical support to Afghan self-help groups led by women.

The display of skill and professionalism by Afghan cricketers during the recently concluded Indian Premier League brought immense joy to all of Afghanistan and to the cricketing world. India is pleased to convey that it is hosting the Afghanistan cricket team for a bilateral series. We hope that this will bring further happiness, encouragement and a sense of celebration to the people of Afghanistan. Sports have a rare power to lift

a nation's spirit, to provide shared moments of pride, hope and joy. We definitely believe that our Afghan brothers and sisters deserve this.

India is also the top destination of Afghan exports. As per the World Bank, 43 per cent of Afghanistan's exports are destined for India. By offering tariff-free access for Afghan goods to Indian markets, we have operationalized a dedicated air freight corridor between India and Afghanistan. We are also supporting Afghan traders by issuing hundreds of gratis long-term business visas. These traders are suffering under unprecedented trade and transit terrorism inflicted upon them by Pakistan's denial of passage for trade. The cynical closure of access for this land-locked country is in total violation of United Nations declarations on land-locked developing countries and a clear weaponization of their trade and transit vulnerabilities. This blatant Pakistani violation of World Trade Organization norms and of the Charter of the United Nations and international law should be condemned by the global community.

The Secretary-General's report (S/2026/431) notes the dire humanitarian concerns and the rising implications for Afghanistan due to the unprecedented scale and pace of forced and involuntary returns under adverse circumstances. This needs the world's attention and necessitates more efforts towards addressing food security, healthcare, water security and other shelter challenges. The returnees need to be provided housing, basic services and livelihoods. The Afghan economy is suffering from the additional burden of returnees. To this end, my country is working with the United Nations agencies and the Afghan authorities to make provisions for housing, food and other essential items to ease the immense pain that has been inflicted on the Afghan people and support their reintegration. We also reiterate the Secretary-General's call on Member States to uphold their international obligations in relation to protection and ensure that returns are voluntary, safe, dignified and accompanied by sustained support for the reintegration of returnees into communities.

India would like to emphasize the importance of UNAMA and its mandate and underline our full support to UNAMA in these challenging times as it endeavours to promote peace and stability in Afghanistan. Pakistan, in its statement earlier today, questioned the intent of UNAMA and the veracity of the Secretary-General's report. We would like to stress that support for multilateralism and the United Nations is not an à la carte menu.

Pakistan's campaign of military air strikes against Afghanistan is causing huge civilian casualties and suffering among the Afghan people. We reiterate the Secretary-General's deep concern at civilian casualties caused by air strikes, cross-border firing and targeted killings, as detailed in UNAMA reports. We support the Secretary-General's call urging compliance with obligations under international law, including international humanitarian law, and ensuring the protection of civilians. We also support UNAMA's earlier calls for investigation to ensure accountability, prevent recurrence and uphold victims' rights. Such unconscionable acts of violence are a blatant assault on Afghanistan's sovereignty and a threat to the region's peace and stability.

India strongly condemns the air strikes on Afghan territory, which are flagrant violations of international law, the United Nations Charter and the principle of State sovereignty. According to UNAMA, 372 civilians have been killed and 397 injured just in the first three months this year, a large majority of them during the holy month of Ramadan — a time of peace, mercy and reflection — which makes the act all the more reprehensible. We reiterate UNAMA's call for compliance with obligations under international humanitarian law, including the principles of precaution, distinction and proportionality, to protect civilians from harm. No faith, no law and no morality can justify these actions.

Let me reiterate: dressing up a massacre as a military operation does not absolve the perpetrator. Killing, maiming and orphaning civilians is not counter-terrorism. Espousing high principles of international law and Islamic solidarity while mercilessly carrying out air strikes during the holy month of Ramadan is the perfect example of hypocrisy. Blaming its neighbours for its own failures is an old Pakistani habit. This attempt to hoodwink the world will fail. Coming up with official notifications directing Pakistan's Government agencies to start referring to groups inside its own borders as Fitna al-Hindustan is nothing but officially sponsored misinformation and disinformation dressed in religious terminology. This is an outcome of an organized factory of hate coming from the deep State of Pakistan, which aims to keep its citizens in a state of permanent hostility with India in order to perpetuate its stay in power and control of national resources and detract from core political and economic problems. The de facto coup by the military through the twenty-seventh constitutional amendment is only its most recent manifestation.

India stands steadfast in rejecting terrorism in all its forms and manifestations. Only coordinated efforts by the international community can ensure that Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant and Al-Qaida and their affiliates, including the Lashkar-e-Tayyiba and Jaish-i-Mohammed and proxies of the Lashkar-e-Tayyiba such as the National Resistance Front, along with those who facilitate their operations, no longer indulge in cross-border terrorism. We call on the international community to work together towards this noble goal.

We lend our voice again to re-emphasize the importance of incentivizing positive actions. The political reality of Afghanistan has changed in the past five years, and the current United Nations sanctions regime must take that into account. The United Nations and international community need policy instruments that aim to benefit the people of Afghanistan and nudge policy in the right direction rather than only wielding tools of punishment that are yielding diminishing returns. The international community must engage with all stakeholders across all formats.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I now give the floor to the representative of Turkmenistan.

Mr. Hajiyev (Turkmenistan): At the outset, I thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon for the comprehensive briefing and commend the continued efforts of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan in facilitating dialogue and coordination among all stakeholders engaged on the Afghan track.

As a neighbouring country sharing a long border with Afghanistan, Turkmenistan remains deeply interested in the earliest possible stabilization and improvement of the situation in that country. Peace, security and sustainable development in Afghanistan are directly linked to the security and prosperity of the entire region. Nearly five years have passed since the current de facto authorities assumed power in Afghanistan. During this period, various measures and countermeasures have been undertaken by different actors, yielding only limited and relative results. At the same time, the overall situation remains fragile and uncertain, with the prospect of prolonged challenges.

In this regard, Turkmenistan believes that the international community should increasingly focus on practical and result-oriented approaches that can bring tangible benefits to the Afghan people, rather than measures that merely contribute to the adaptation of the de facto authorities to existing restrictions and pressures. From the standpoint of regional security, Turkmenistan, together with other Central Asian countries, places particular emphasis on maintaining and expanding trade, economic and infrastructure cooperation with Afghanistan. We are convinced that sustainable economic development, job creation, access to energy and transport connectivity constitute essential prerequisites for lasting peace and stability in Afghanistan.

In this context, Turkmenistan continues to advance major regional infrastructure initiatives involving Afghanistan. These include the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India gas pipeline, the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan power transmission project and railway and transport connectivity projects. As of June, approximately 130 kilometres of the challenging mountainous section of the Afghan segment of the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India gas pipeline has been opened, with around 40 kilometres of pipeline already laid. Completion of this section is planned for December. Work is also progressing on the 23-kilometre railway extension from Aqina to Andkhoy towards Shibirghan, and the construction of the railway terminal in Toraghundi is expected to be completed in December. We wish to emphasize that infrastructure and development projects have always served the people of a country rather than any particular regime or individual.

Turkmenistan highly values the Doha process. At the same time, it may be useful to complement existing mechanisms with other regional formats. In this regard, consideration could be given to revitalizing broader regional consultations, such as the Six plus Two group involving Afghanistan's neighbouring countries, as well as Afghanistan and Russia.

We remain concerned about the situation regarding the rights of women and girls in Afghanistan. While continued advocacy on this issue is important, additional practical measures should be undertaken to facilitate greater participation of Afghan women in educational, humanitarian, professional and international engagement initiatives. In this regard, Turkmenistan stands ready to provide practical assistance and support efforts aimed at expanding opportunities for Afghan women in these areas.

In conclusion, Turkmenistan calls upon all stakeholders engaged on the Afghan track to intensify efforts aimed at identifying a practical, balanced and forward-looking approach to Afghanistan, with the ultimate objective of ensuring peace, stability and sustainable development for the Afghan people and the region as a whole.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I now give the floor to the representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Mr. Iravani (Islamic Republic of Iran): I thank you, Madam President, for convening this meeting. At the outset, we congratulate Colombia on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month. We also commend China for its effective leadership and successful presidency of the Council during the month of May. We thank Ms. Gagnon, Deputy Special Representative, and Ms. Wosornu, Director, Crisis Response Division, for their insightful briefings. We listen to the statement delivered by Ms. Mehran. We take note of the Secretary-General's latest report (S/2026/431).

The report indicates that Afghanistan continues to face complex challenges, including a deteriorating humanitarian and economic situation, restrictions affecting women and girls and the persistent threat posed by terrorist groups. At the same time, the report also notes certain areas of economic stabilization and efforts by the de facto authorities to maintain governance and advanced economic activity, which deserve acknowledgment. In this context, I wish to underline the following points.

First, we remain concerned about the worsening humanitarian and economic conditions in Afghanistan. As of 30 April, the 2026 Afghanistan humanitarian needs response plan remains significantly underfunded at 14 per cent. We reiterate our call to the international community and donors to provide increased, predictable and flexible funding to sustain life-saving humanitarian operations. Efforts aimed at economic recovery should be supported, assets frozen should be released unconditionally and obstacles that hinder economic stabilization should be removed. Humanitarian assistance must remain impartial and free from politicization.

Secondly, continued international engagement with the de facto authorities remains indispensable for advancing stability and addressing Afghanistan's challenges. The Secretary-General's report reaffirms the importance of the comprehensive approach consisting of principled and pragmatic engagement. Constructive dialogue remains essential to address humanitarian, economic, counter-narcotics-related and governance-related issues. In this regard, the Doha process continues to provide an important platform for practical cooperation. Iran has actively participated in the working groups on counter-narcotics and the private sector under this process and supports efforts aimed at enhancing regional and international cooperation. We welcome the significant reduction in opium poppy cultivation in Afghanistan, which represents an important achievement with positive global implications. However, as highlighted in the report, the economic consequences for rural communities remain severe. Without sustained investment in alternative livelihoods, rural development and access to markets, the improvements achieved might not be sustainable. We also note growing concerns regarding the expansion of synthetic drugs production and trafficking, which require enhanced international cooperation.

Thirdly, the continued deprivation of women and girls of their fundamental rights remains a matter of concern. Restrictions on education, employment, freedom of movement and participation in public life not only undermine human dignity but also hinder Afghanistan's long-term development and economic recovery. Such measures are incompatible with the true teachings of Islam. We call on the de facto authorities to remove these restrictions and to ensure that women and girls can enjoy their rights, including access to education and employment. Similarly, Afghanistan is an integral part of the region and the rich and ancient Persian civilization, and it is essential that the rights, identity and cultural heritage of all ethnic and national communities in Afghanistan be fully respected and protected. We believe that constructive international engagement remains the most effective means of encouraging and promoting the protection of human rights, including the rights of women and ethnic and religious communities.

Fourthly, the security situation in Afghanistan remains a source of serious concern. The threat posed by terrorist groups, including the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant-Khorasan, continues to endanger Afghanistan and the wider region. Afghanistan must never become a safe haven for terrorism, nor should its territory be used to threaten or undermine the security of other States, particularly neighbouring countries. We also express concern at the recent tensions between our two brotherly neighbours, Afghanistan and Pakistan, and welcome ongoing regional efforts aimed at promoting dialogue, confidence-building and lasting stability between them. We echo the Secretary-General's call for restraint, de-escalation and a peaceful resolution of differences through dialogue and diplomacy. We welcome regional mediation efforts and encourage the parties to pursue sustainable arrangements that promote stability and good relations.

Fifthly, neighbouring countries continue to bear a disproportionate share of the consequences arising from the situation in Afghanistan. Regional cooperation mechanisms and initiatives among neighbouring countries, such as the Moscow format and the Shanghai Cooperation Organization Afghanistan Contact Group, therefore remain indispensable for promoting sustainable peace, security and development in Afghanistan. The Islamic Republic of Iran, sharing a long border with Afghanistan, has, for more than four decades, hosted millions of Afghan nationals and provided them with access to education, healthcare and other essential services. This long-standing commitment reflects Iran's continued dedication to supporting the Afghan people and to contributing to the stability and security of Afghanistan and the broader region. The international community must provide greater support to countries hosting Afghan refugees and migrants.

Lastly, the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) continues to play a vital and indispensable role in supporting the Afghan people by facilitating dialogue, coordinating international assistance and advancing a coherent international approach towards Afghanistan. In this context, the Special Representative plays a vital role in fostering constructive engagement with the de facto authorities. Iran supports the expeditious appointment of a qualified and suitable candidate, while taking into account the views and considerations of the Afghan authorities so as to facilitate effective dialogue and cooperation. We also reaffirm our support for the extension of UNAMA's mandate for its effective impartial and balanced implementation. In this regard, we appreciate the efforts of China, as penholder, in preparing and submitting the draft resolution for an extension of UNAMA's mandate for an additional year (S/2026/170) and its continued constructive engagement with other members of the Security Council throughout the negotiations process. Iran remains committed to close cooperation with the United Nations, neighbouring countries, regional organizations and all relevant stakeholders in pursuit of a stable, peaceful and prosperous Afghanistan that is fully integrated into the international community.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): I would like to remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to enable the Council to carry out its work expeditiously.

I now give the floor to the representative of Uzbekistan.

Mr. Lapasov (Uzbekistan): We thank Ms. Georgette Gagnon for her comprehensive briefing.

Uzbekistan reiterates its strong support for the activities of the United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA) and welcomes its continued efforts to assist the Afghan people and facilitate constructive international engagement with Afghanistan. In this regard, we support an extension of UNAMA's mandate and the preservation of its central coordinating role in international efforts related to Afghanistan. We believe that the United Nations should continue to play a leading role in promoting a coordinated and balanced approach towards Afghanistan, aimed at ensuring peace, stability and sustainable development.

Uzbekistan supports the Doha process as the principal international platform for engagement with the de facto authorities. We are convinced that long-term stability in Afghanistan cannot be achieved through humanitarian assistance alone. Greater attention should be devoted to economic recovery, job creation, infrastructure development, regional economic integration and respect for women and girls' rights. In this regard, we underscore the growing importance of regional connectivity initiatives linking Central and South Asia. Projects in the fields of transport, trade, energy and logistics can make a significant contribution to Afghanistan's economic resilience and long-term stability. We also note the increasing role of Central Asian countries in supporting Afghanistan through trade, humanitarian assistance and practical cooperation.

Uzbekistan remains committed to advancing regional connectivity, including the potential of the Termiz international transport and logistics hub and the Termiz dialogue on connectivity between Central and South Asia. We further emphasize the importance of supporting sustainable economic development, expanding trade and transit opportunities and strengthening Afghanistan's integration in the regional economic process. In this context, we welcome the growing recognition of the role of Central Asian countries in supporting Afghanistan's stability and development and remain committed to forging the strengthening of constructive regional cooperation.

In conclusion, Uzbekistan stands ready to continue close cooperation with UNAMA, regional partners and the international community in support of a peaceful, stable and economically self-sufficient Afghanistan.

The President (*spoke in Spanish*): The representative of Pakistan has asked for the floor to make a further statement.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): I have in fact been compelled to respond to some of the comments made by the representative of Afghanistan. I should not say representative because Mr. Faiq is occupying the seat, and I fully sympathize and empathize with him about his predicament, but he is not representing anyone from Afghanistan. We listened to Ms. Mehran today in this meeting, who is actually representing civil society. Mr. Faiq does not even have those credentials. On the whole, he made a statement that made a lot of sense, except for his remarks about Pakistan's counter-terrorism operations. This was unfortunate because we explained in our statement what the rationale was for those remarks.

Let me repeat that Pakistan's actions, including those conducted in March, were directed solely against the terrorist and military support infrastructure that is operating from Afghanistan. It is in no way directed against the brotherly people of Afghanistan. These targets included drone storage and technical support infrastructure and ammunition storage sites that were being used by the Afghan Taliban regime to carry out attacks against innocent Pakistani civilians. These strikes were precise, deliberate and professional. No hospital, drug rehabilitation centre or civilian facility was targeted by these strikes. As part of established practice, video footage of all six strikes was released by the Ministry of Information shortly after the operation, clearly showing the nature of the targets. The secondary explosions visible in the footage further confirmed that ammunition storage facilities were indeed struck with precision. All insinuations to the contrary are therefore not based on facts and are just propaganda.

Secondly, we had this discussion today based on the report from the Secretary-General (S/2026/431). We heard statements from Council members and others who are not members of the Council. Everyone will have noticed that this discussion represented a complex situation, and a lot of concerns were expressed by Council members and non-Council members. The three key expectations of the international community were at the core of this discussion, namely inclusive good governance; human rights and women and girls' rights; and counter-terrorism. The third commitment is that Afghan soil will not be allowed to be used for terrorism against any country. These were at the heart of the discussion. We clearly heard that there were condemnations. There were expressions of concern with regard to all three of these points, which are the main expectations of the international community regarding the Afghan Taliban. There were clear demands from the majority of those who took the floor for the Taliban regime to comply with those commitments, perhaps with the exception of one representative, the representative of India, so I feel obliged to respond to that as well.

It does not come as a surprise to us to hear such comments made by the Indian representative, who has since left. We listened to a long list of so-called development and humanitarian activities and support that India is purportedly carrying out in Afghanistan. It seemed that it was just a long prologue to something that he actually intended to say and something that he actually wanted to utilize and abuse this forum for, and that was to target Pakistan. To us, it is absolutely clear. India's key aims and objectives in Afghanistan, although in the garb and under the guise of development or humanitarian assistance, are solely driven by the singular goal of destabilizing Pakistan, including by using terrorist groups operating from Afghan soil. They include Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan (TTP), which so many of my colleagues around the table have condemned, and the Baloch Liberation Army (BLA), which acts as a proxy of India to perpetrate terrorism inside Pakistan. In fact, I thank him because I myself omitted

mentioning this. I thank him for reminding everyone in the Council and those who were listening that the BLA's other name is Fitna al-Hindustan — yes, that is what it is. It is an organization that is supported and financed by India to destabilize and target Pakistan. I think that for some time we have perhaps been amused to listen to India's new-found love for the Taliban. We know all the history and what is there in the background. All those years, we have known what India's position was. But for us, this is not a coincidence. This shift of policy comes on the heels of Pakistan's successful counter-terrorism operations against the terrorist hideouts and camps that are operating inside Afghanistan with the active support of India.

As I said before, Mr. Faiq, for once, condemned terrorism emanating from Afghanistan that is directed towards Pakistan, that is affecting Pakistan and that is costing us the lives of hundreds of Pakistani nationals, including women, children and our security and law enforcement personnel. But I am sure Council members will have noticed that not once did the representative of India condemn the TTP or the BLA — yes, Fitna al-Hindustan — who have been carrying out attacks and targeting innocent Pakistanis, who have tragically lost their lives at the hands of these terrorists. We are not astonished. We are not surprised at all because we know very well that India's hostile policies and complicity are further validated by the remarks of its representative today. And I seriously believe that this behaviour should be a cause for concern for the Security Council and the international community because, as I was mentioning earlier, more than 1,200 Pakistanis lost their lives last year alone. They were human beings with families like all of us, with ambitions, with hopes for a better future. But they were silenced by a group of cowardly terrorists backed by a country whose representative was trying to lecture the Council and, in fact, in the process, that was actually trying to mask its own involvement in this bloodshed that is happening in Pakistan.

So, it obviously must be discomforting for India to see its terrorist infrastructure being dismantled and destroyed in Afghanistan by Pakistan's valiant security forces, who, I must say, and, I repeat, will continue to do whatever is necessary for our self-defence. India was calling on others to comply with international law and adhere to the dictates of humanity. It would be laughable if we were not aware of India's own record and if the matter under consideration in the Council were not that serious, for we know that India's true face is truly exposed before the international community. It is a serial violator of international law. For decades, it has been in illegal occupation of Jammu and Kashmir, which is an international dispute on the agenda of the Council, and where it has been engaged in gross and systematic violations of human rights in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir. And we were talking about violations of human rights — women's rights and girls' rights in Afghanistan. How can we be quiet about these grave, persistent, systematic violations of human rights, reported and corroborated by the international community, human rights organizations and the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, which India has been perpetrating in the Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir for decades?

And it is not just that. India talks about democracy and the rule of law, while we are also aware of its own conduct inside its country, its persecution of minorities, including Muslims, Christians and Sikhs, and other Indian citizens, who dare not raise their voice. It talks about disinformation. Its entire national media is under the control of the Bharatiya Janata Party's Government, which has total control of the narrative. It is a State sponsor of terrorism, not just in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir or in Pakistan using Afghan soil; it is also openly abetting and financing terrorism elsewhere. Extraterritorial assassinations in North America, in Canada and in the United States — the international community is now well aware of them. Everything has been exposed. And India talks of international law. It is in serious breach of Security Council resolutions on Jammu and Kashmir. It has seriously violated the Indus Waters Treaty by

declaring that it is holding the Treaty in abeyance, without any reason or justification, in complete defiance of the Treaty's provisions and international law.

There are so many things that I could have continued to say. The representative was talking about cricket and sportsman spirit — and we see the quality of its sportsman spirit when it refuses to play or refuses to shake hands with the other players. And then the country comes to the Council and tells us what cricket and sports could bring in terms of peace and harmony.

I therefore think that we should also seriously consider how we allow countries to take the floor in the Council and under what rules and etiquette they should be speaking in the Council. My advice simply would be for India to do a bit of introspection. It can do that by discontinuing its policies of aggression, subversion and sabotage against neighbouring countries, particularly Pakistan. It must look inwards and try to address its own problems rather than spreading disinformation and politicizing debates and discussions. Pakistan is well aware of India's motives and evil designs, but we will not allow them to nourish terrorists and threaten our national security. We have stopped them before, and we will do it again. We will always stop them.

The President (*spoke in Spanish)*: The representative of Afghanistan has asked for the floor to make a further statement.

I now give him the floor.

Mr. Faiq (Afghanistan): I had not intended to take the floor, but I am compelled to briefly respond to the remarks made by the representative of Pakistan, particularly with regard to the personal references directed at me.

First, I would respectfully urge all delegations to uphold the standards of decorum and mutual respect that should guide our work in the Chamber. Personal attacks do not advance constructive dialogue.

Secondly, I am proud to represent Afghanistan and speak on behalf of millions of Afghans, whose voices deserve to be heard. And I am a proud representative of a democratically elected Government that was toppled by the same group, the Taliban, that was supported by the Government of Pakistan. And today the representative of Pakistan is complaining about it. My remarks were not directed against the people of Pakistan, to whom we are grateful for graciously hosting Afghan refugees in very difficult times, but against policies that have had profound consequences for Afghanistan and, increasingly, for the region. For years, the Afghan Government emphasized genuinely combating terrorism, without any distinctions, and warned about the double standards, adverse consequences and dangers of supporting and harbouring the Taliban and other proxy groups. Those warnings were ignored. Today, Pakistan itself is confronting many of the same challenges Afghanistan warned about.

Thirdly, the Afghan people must not pay the price for Pakistan's failed policies and the Taliban's actions. Nor can they afford the proxy or regional rivalries between Pakistan and India. Afghanistan wants to stay independent, and the Afghan people should not be victims. One cannot expect Tehrik-e Taliban Afghanistan, which is the Taliban in Afghanistan, to prevent Tehrik-e Taliban Pakistan from attacks against Pakistan. Combating terrorism requires a responsible, legitimate Government committed to its national and international obligations in Afghanistan.

Finally, neither airstrikes nor exchange of blame will bring peace and security to Afghanistan or Pakistan. What is needed is a adopting a paradigm shift in policies and addressing the underlying causes of instability through constructive engagement, non-interference, mutual respect, dialogue and genuine commitment. As a neighbouring country and as a member of the Council representing the Group of Asia-Pacific States,

Pakistan is well positioned to support an inclusive and sustainable political process in which the Afghan people themselves determine the future of their country.

The President (*spoke in Spanish)*: The representative of Pakistan has asked for the floor to make a further statement.

Mr. Ahmad (Pakistan): I offer apologies for taking the floor again. I do not want to belabour the point, but this is exactly what I was saying. There are many things that need to be addressed in how the situation in Afghanistan can best be tackled by the international community. And the members of the Council and of the international community have their views. They share those views, we have an exchange and we see how this is to be done in the best possible manner.

For example, on the role of United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan, we are negotiating and discussing a draft resolution that will renew its mandate. The point here is that we need to have this discussion with anyone who represents anyone in some capacity. And the comments that we received are not very useful. Pakistan knows what our responsibilities are. And Pakistan also engages in dialogue and diplomacy. Pakistan also knows how to protect its citizens against terrorism. I will end there.

The meeting rose at 1.20 p.m.